



YOGTANTRAGAMA
ISSN NO: 2454-888X



Jan- March 2018

From the Editor in Chief's desk:

By Swami Paranand Tirth

EDITOR IN CHIEF: SWAMI PARANAND TIRTH



Twilight, a Sketch by Frederic Edwin Church, 1858
Picture courtesy artistnetwork.com

From the chief editors desk ..

The twilight zone of Shakta and Shambhava

Shambhava is a mind set born of perfect quietude a well controlled movement of senses towards their perception, a calm placid mind that absorbs all divergence and a clear head or distinct discriminatory wisdom are the sine quo

none of the intuitive insight into one's own essential nature i.e. the self evident shiva .

Shiva or the ultimate as a vedantist would put it is not a produce of any modification, he isn't attained through any effort ,or is not a resultant of any refinement or rectification nor is the universal self cultured or processed in any manner so not only refraining from all dynamic

pursuit is the key but also a well calculated and conscious withdrawal from the objective phenomena is equally essential . Gita tells us “One should withdraw by and by with an intelligence guided by patience . Having seated the mind in the self disperse all thoughts and "think nothing". This not thinking any thing or transcending all expressions is what is referred to as shambhav upaya .

Without a genuine preceptor sharing his spiritual insight with you this process is as tedious as emptying an ocean by removing water with the tip of kusha blade . This avesh or trance dawns upon an aspirant ,of the most high degree of competence ,by the awakening of a preceptor which again is without any verbal communication ,as he i.e. the aspirant is completely thoughtless is called shambhava .

ShAkta upaya is all about incessant effort and strenuous exercising of the individual will . This is the most cherished and applauded feat of human endeavours ,but it is only penultimate and the most paradoxical scheme of events is that there is no bridge connecting the penultimate and the ultimate ! . Till the realisation of the per se unison with the supreme self one is obsessed with the notion of this realisation as a product of some effect .The Upanishads propound that "the undoing is not accomplished by doing " undoing in this context aims at अकृतः or emancipation which is per se where as कृतेन means through karmas or efforts . so there has been a great dispute over relating the two means i.e. shambhav and shAkta or unrelating the two . There have been sects which are deeply rooted in the societal reticulum based on either only the former or an admixture of the two or exclusively on the latter even by rejecting the former in toto .

There are staunch ritualist who deny even the consistency of that portion of the Vedas which is not conducive to karmas specially the Vedic rituals .Then there are others who would rather correlate both as conducive to each other . Action leads to knowledge and

knowledge reinforces karmas and makes them more efficacious and fruitful .

The Gita vindicates these as

“A man desirous of climbing upon the seat of yoga must perform karmas where as the same man when actually gets seated in yoga .i.e. divine communion must refrain from the divergent action and retain quietude and placidity”.

आरुरुक्षोः मुनेर्योगं कर्मकारणमुच्यते
योगारूढस्य तस्यैव शमः कारणमुच्यते ।

This means to say that till you attain the state of shambhavi continue with karmas and after you have actually gained it shun all karmas . There is yet another hard core ilk of thinkers they provide the axiom of - it's better not to soil your hands instead of washing it after they are dirty . If karmas have to be abandoned to identify oneself with one's essential nature why start them in the first place . This lot traces their lineage back to the four offsprings of brahma or god the creator .They were inspired by their father to multiply their progeny but they defied him and sought to attain and retain their essential nature . The three lineages became so complicatedly juxtaposed in the oriental pantheon that an individual was not left with anything clear cut to pursue .

Agamas and Tantra are the instruments of the munificence of Parameshwara which as it were dawned upon humankind to deliver it from this jargon of directionlessness. There schema of Charya ,yoga and Jnan is to graduate an aspirant successively into the cult of self realisation through shambhav upaya and to evolve the novice as competent enough for the ultimate epiphany by training him through the means of effort and concentration .

Theravada Buddhism also adopted the same method of the sequence of sheel samadhi and prajna/vipassana. This is to facilitate the intuitive insight called prajna and vipashyana by an assiduous adherence to the preceding steps

of sheel or conduct and samadhi or meditation . The Tantra do not expect a guru to induce the trance of shambhav straight away . it may crashland or rapture the subtle core of the novice . charya for refining the grossser part of the aspirant yoga the subtler one and causal portion of the aspirant by shambhav upaya is the crux of almost all agamas . Needless to say that every aspirant has his own gradation of refinement so one might as well go briefly about the pre requisites and begin with the shambhav straight away. Utpala one of the most illustrious preceptors of the shaivite doctrine, only salutes such Adepts of real devotion and doesn't compare himself to them .

नध्यायतो नजपतः स्याद्यस्याविधिपूर्वकं

एवमेव शिवाभासस्तं नुमः भक्तिशालिनम्

“We make obeisance to all such great devotees who are possessed by their own shiva hood

spontaneously ,without repeating his mantra or meditating on his profile or by not even worshiping his relics and icons as per the scriptural injunctions”.

Swamiparanand tirth

Founder President and CEO

YTA yoga Tantra and Agama (inc.) cal .USA.

Head administrator

Yoga Tantra et agama centre

Montreal Quebec Canada .

Editorial



Humanity has always been torn between making efforts and realizing that most of the times the result has had nothing to do with the said effort. The momentary pleasure or satisfaction one might derive at completion of a task or a duty is too short lived and thus gives rise to a new journey towards a new effort, new challenges, new ways of testing one's capabilities.

Many a times an entire life-time may be spent in 'proving' oneself to the family society and to oneself. This results in taking pride in such achievements and often one may get obsessed with it and start identifying oneself with one's success and position not realizing how trivial it is to associate one's happiness with it.

Explaining the importance of Shambava upaya in the editorial our guru Swami Paranand Tirthji stresses on the need to converge all one's thoughts and actions and withdraw from excess objectivity. For an aspirant who truly wants to experience the bliss of Shiva-hood Shambava upaya is the key. Shambhava is a mind set born of perfect quietude a well controlled movement of senses towards their perception, a calm placid mind that absorbs all divergence and a clear head or distinct discriminatory wisdom are the sine qua non of the intuitive insight into one's own essential nature i.e. the self evident shiva.

With the blessings and divine guidance of Swamiji we have been able to publish ten issues of the YTA newsletter and in this eleventh issue we are re-publishing some thought provoking

articles and papers which have been published in previous issues.

To begin with we have an interesting and analytical write-up by Niraj Kumar on the significance of 'lotus' in Indian and other eastern traditions. The author observes that apart from the simile of lotus used to describe the rising from the samsara & achieving full blooming Enlightenment, it apparently contains the properties of an "Enlightened Being" unto itself and goes on to analyze it in detail.

'Quitessence of the highest Purpose: A translation, introduction and analysis of Sri Abhinavagupta's Paramarthasara' is the title of an erudite article by Dr. Jeffrey S. Lidke. In this essay, the author has attempted to illuminate how the Paramārthasāra, a seminal text by Abhinavagupta serves as a guide for the process of the awakening and internal ascension of kuṇḍalinī-śakti.

This is followed by an enlightening article by Prof Subhash Kak on 'Art and Cosmology in India'. According to him the best way to understand India is through its art and the cosmology. He stresses that textbook narratives often overlook the synthesizing principles that represent the grammar of Indian culture, and they are much like the accounts of the six blind people who encountering an elephant describe it as wall, spear, snake, tree, rope, and fan, respectively.

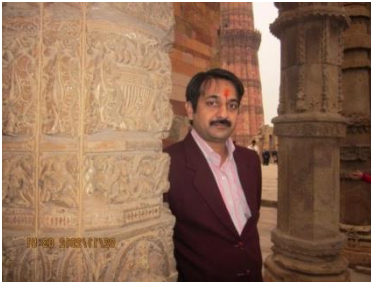
Next we have Swamiji's conversations with Dr. Sisir Roy on the nature of vibration and quantum vacuum, a notion that has been engaging and intriguing modern day scientists. The questions raised by the latter have been succinctly answered by Swamiji citing relevant examples wherever necessary. The concepts that quantum physics is dealing with have been contemplated upon by hoary seers and given due importance in their writings. Some of these notions like Spanda, Maatrisva and Chidakasha have been discussed in these extremely perceptive and discerning correspondences.

Following this we have a nostalgic piece by Ambika Talwar about her pilgrimage to the holy land of Rishikesh in the foothills of mighty Himalayas. A lucid narrative with bits of poetry strewn in between makes it a very charming read. While on one hand it describes the wonderful experiences and interactions, on the other it also pleads for maintaining the sanctity of such holy places and not reduce them to sites of tourist attraction.

In addition to these we have the second and concluding part of the travelogue 'Southern Sojourns' by Dr G.L Kaw, narrating the author's latest visit to South Indian temples. This illustrated and detailed narrative provides a very handy information for future pilgrims with apt references to the historical and legendary incidences.

In the end we have a brief description about our website and google classroom where Swamiji teaches the faraway aspirant about the arcane secrets hidden in agamic texts.

(Dr.Geetika Kaw Kher is Asst. Professor at Amity School of Fine Arts (ASFA) and teaches History of Art, Aesthetics and Art Criticism)



Lotus, Full Moon, & Buddha's Enlightenment

Niraj Kumar

On 4th May, 2015, Buddha Jayanti was celebrated. This is the Buddhapurnima Day(Vesak), the day of Buddha's Enlightenment. Gautama was born on Full Moon, attained enlightenment and died (Mahaparinirvana) on Full Moon. Full Moon & Buddha's life/legend is deeply intertwined. It is said that after five auspicious dreams and 6 years of wandering, at the age of 35; when he sat under the sacred fig tree(Peepal tree) at Bodhgaya, with a vow that he won't get up without knowing the Truth; there was tremor of joy across universe. He passed through 49 days of meditation and four stages of consciousness. Finally, he achieved True knowledge, the wheel of karma, law of causation and the eight-fold noble path to cross the cycle of trans-migration. With the full moon rising, his mind passed through various states and before the dawn, he gazed at the morning star and realized that the realization is stable and permanent like this morning star in the vast sky. In Buddhist symbolism, blossoming lotus describes metonymically the arising of Buddha-nature. Full Moon, lotus and Buddha nature blooms in structural resonance.

I am deeply engrossed comprehending the underlying connection of symbolism and events and discourses. Gautama's eight fold path, Panini's eight fold realm of matricakra concerning origin of linguistic universe, eight-fold theory of music, eight kind of rasas in aesthetics, eightfold yoga of Patanjali, eight fold universe of saktis with ninth, the bindu as potentiality) in SriCakra/Tantra, eight planet

system of the Sun, propensity of atom to gain stability with 8 electron in valance shell, eight-fold symmetry as the potential highest solution for a United Field Theory in mathematics seems to be entrained at some common junction. Similarly, Gautama's Four Noble Truths with the fourth as the way to transcend the first three reveals the four- fold structure of being as well as language in Indic system. Vedic rishis discovered 'catusyapad' as the way to comprehend the reality. There are set of threes and the fourth as the way to transcend. Fourth is the turiya. Three gunas, three purushartha, three Vedas, three states of consciousness, three -fold division of Kala(time) and so on. And the fourth in each aspect signifies the transcendence. Gautama's Four-fold Truth is encapsulated in similar structure. Fourth is the way to transcend and as found in Indic tradition the Way is always Eight-fold. I am tempted to put therefore Gautama's awakening as the awakening of a Vedic seer reiterating the Truth discovered by the predecessors.

But, whereas Vedic seers were more engaged with the sun and fire in their approach towards rituals, it is strange that Buddha's disciples took up the opposite, "Moon and water" to symbolize their own way of liberation. Hence, we find how in Buddha's legend, the blooming Moon is projected as the defining characteristic of important events.

Lotus (*Kamala*, Botanical name *Nelumbo nucifera* Gaertn)has always been a sacred flower in the East due to its peculiar properties. Most of us are aware that it grows in muddy water, moves upward towards light. Above the surface of dirty water, it blooms. Buddha used the simile of lotus to preach the virtue of purity, emergence and achievement. It is interesting that Buddha is shown as sitting on a lotus flower in Lotus position (Padmasana) with a lotus in hand and a 1000-petalled lotus blooming in head. Like Full Moon, lotus encapsulates Buddha's enlightenment. Both symbolisms converge in head. Buddha saw 1000 Full Moon in life. He departed at the age of 80 (~1000 full moons). Buddha with

thousand-petalled lotus blooms had auspicious experience of thousand full- moon night.

I am particularly surprised with the recent advances in unraveling biological properties of lotus. Lotus is a unique plant that regulates the temperature without any neuro-endocrinal system as found in the warm-blooded animals like human beings. Surprisingly, the temperature range is very narrow (86-95 degree F). Lotus is exceptional in increasing oxygen intake and release of more carbon dioxide at night used in converting more carbohydrate to energy just like warm-blooded animals do during cold. This heat production tapers off at the dawn. Seventy lotus flowers can produce as much heat as a human body.

Lotus has another property to self-cleanse. Microscopic structure on lotus leaf creates a water-repellant surface. Raindrops can't stick and these roll off cleansing the dust. This property has been termed as "lotus-effect" in the field of nano-technology. Now, nano-engineers as well as NASA rocket scientists want to harness this property of lotus to create a self-cleansing toilet, rocket shell, clothes etc.



Lotus seeds are also known for its endurance and permanence. Lotus seeds have been found dormant for thousand years and then suddenly sprouting into a healthy plant. This property is under investigation to learn more about anti-ageing properties. Lotus pod looks like human heart and on blooming like the cerebral surface. Heart contains the potentiality to bloom into full awakening of mind.



Apart from the simile of lotus used to describe the rising from the samsara & achieving full blooming Enlightenment, it is apparent that lotus contains the properties of an "Enlightened Being" unto itself. It rises from beneath and immediately returns back to the source. With the bloom, it prepares to shed the seeds, like an enlightened being who is active to propagate virtue. The flowers and the plants rise with the dawn and set in the dusk in consonance with solar rhythm and yet are active during night by producing more heat attracting countless insects. When other plants sleep, lotus is active and awake and helps the needy multitude with warmth like a compassionate Being. Each part of lotus is edible and useful. May it be rhizome, roots, stem, flower and seed just like the full utility of an Enlightened being in every aspect. For the welfare of the world, lotus continue to self-cleanse, a virtue aspired by seekers. Surprisingly, lotus maintains temperature which is in the range of an Enlightened being i.e. slightly below normal human temperature due to the cooling caused by secretions when the energies awaken each part of brain (*shithlikaran*). The sign of an enlightened being is hypothermic condition described as the "cool shower of the Moon" in scriptures and esoteric tradition. This happens due to a coherence of cells at highest level that entails maximum efficiency of energy and minimum production of heat. If one sees the open pod of lotus flower that contains seed in honey-comb structure, this looks similar to the image of thousand-petalled lotus bloom in the head of a Buddha. From seed to flower, lotus contains same property of blooming, self-purification, attraction and utility. Seeds contain the secret of immortality. Lotus symbolizes flowerification of Perfect Being.

This is the reason that India, the land of spiritual fervour, has adopted Lotus as the National Flower. The Vedic seers mention the flower under the name of Pundarika. In Hindu cosmogonic myths, lotus is associated with the creator Prajapati. In The Mahabharata, the creator God, Brahma, is mentioned as having sprung from the lotus that grew out of Vishnu's navel. Lotus is also known as the *Sripushpa*-the auspicious flower. The Srividya sadhna which is the highest ritual worship of the universal creatrix in the form of Mother Goddess amply demonstrates the auspiciousness of the flower. The deity holds the flower in her hands. In fact, iconographic representation of almost every female deity in Indic tradition shows a lotus bud in the hand.

Lotus is also associated with supernatural birth. The bud appears as a human womb. The Second Buddha, Padmasambhava is said to be lotus-born. There are plethoras of birth-stories associated with the lotus flower. In fact, the mythological land of immortal sages is said to be abundant in lakes filled with lotus. Lotus is associated with the idea of immortality not only in Indic tradition, but also in other world-cultures. It has something to do with the transformation of lotus into the shape of cobra upon its death. Even in death, the lotus inspires. It is not without symbolic underpinning that Kundalini, the cobra-shaped esoteric energy that can take a seeker to the realm of immortality, is assumed to pierce the lotus-cakras of a yogi/tantric. And in this symbolism is condensed the Indian spiritual wisdom!

(Niraj Kumar is associated with Society for Asian Integration. He is a disciple of Swami Ranganathanandaji Maharaj of Ramakrishna Mission.)



Quintessence of the highest Purpose: A translation, introduction and analysis of SriAbhhinavagupta's Paramarthsara

(Section of the text sans references: Complete paper published in Journal of Indian Research, Vol 1, No.4, Oct-Dec 2013)

Dr. Jeffrey S. Lidke

Abstract

Abhinavagupta (ca. 975-1025 C.E.) is the greatest synthesizer of Indian Tantric thought and practice. His works influenced and shaped theoretical paradigms in the field of Indian aesthetics, Tantra, literature, and philosophy. In this paper, the author examines the 105 verses of Abhinavagupta's Paramārthasāra (Quintessence of the Highest Purpose) in which Abhinavagupta articulates his philosophy of absolute monism, known popularly as Kashmir Śaivism. An earlier Paramārthasāra was composed by the South Indian legendary saint, Ādiśeṣa during the sixth century, some four hundred years before Abhinavagupta. Abhinavagupta's reinvention of this older text indicates the constant transaction of ideas between Kashmir and South India, Vaiṣṇavite and Śaivite sects. The present shape of Indian thought emerged only as a result of the fusion and appropriation of different thought-streams. A translation of the Paramārthasāra along with an introduction into Abhinavagupta's Monistic

Śaivism has been herewith attempted.

Keywords: *ābhāsa, Anuttara, kuṇḍalinī-śakti, Paramaśiva, Para Samvit, sahāsrāra, satguru, tattva, Trika, twilight language.*

Introduction

The writings of the famous Tāntric guru and philosopher, Abhinavagupta (ca. 975-1025 C.E.), represent some of the finest reflections of Indian religio-philosophical thought. Of his many extant works, the Paramārthasāra (Quintessence of the Highest Purpose) offers a succinct distillation of Abhinavagupta's literary and philosophical genius while also encapsulating the system of esoteric practices at the heart of his Tāntric system. The one-hundred-and-five verses of this composite text lay out the śaivite vision of the universe as the unfolding of a unitary consciousness, called verily Paramaśiva, Para Samvit, Caitanya, Cit Śakti, and Anuttara. Through a process of hierarchical manifestation, this Supreme Principle assumes the form of thirty-six evolutes (tattvas), and in this way, projects the universe of diverse objects upon its own screen. At the core of this universal projection, the absolute assumes the form of the limited human experiencer. Veiling itself with the three cloaks (trimala), Paramaśiva assumes self-limitation (saṅkocana). Yet, this contracted experience is only temporary. Through the awakening of coiled power (kuṇḍalinī-śakti) received in Tantric initiation (dīkṣā) the limited agent (kartā) internally ascends the ladder of tattvas and reclaims his status as the omnipotent Absolute.

In this essay, I have attempted to illuminate how the Paramārthasāra serves as a guide for this process of the awakening and internal ascension of kuṇḍalinī-śakti. Towards this end, I have rendered my own translation of the text and have written a brief introduction and commentary with the aim of framing for the reader the context in which Abhinavagupta penned his masterful text. In this way it is

hoped that my essay serves as an introduction to both the text and the Trika-Kaula tradition in which it arises. By tracing the history of this tradition, and by analyzing its fusion of philosophy and practice in the context of tantric sādhana, I hope to provide an illuminating glimpse into one of the most gifted minds in the history of Indian civilization.

Contextualizing The Text

As a guide for this voyage into the uncharted realm of Tantric practice, we will follow the map drawn by Abhinavagupta in his condensed text, the *Paramārthasāra* (PS). In 105 ārya-ghaṭa verses, this cryptic and highly codified text details the fourfold path (*upāya-catuṣṭayam*) to realization (*śivattva*).

The first English rendering of this text appeared in 1910 in an article entitled “The Paramarthasara of Abhinava-Gupta” by L. D. Barnett.¹ In the preface to this outdated yet useful translation, Barnett writes that his intention in publishing the PS is part of a further project in proving that the “living faith of the majority of modern Tamils is in almost every respect...the same doctrine that was taught in Kashmir about the beginning of the eleventh century by Abhinavagupta.”² This argument for a connection between southern and northern śaiva traditions is clearly strengthened by the fact that Abhinavagupta’s work is based on an earlier southern text of the same name.³ Interestingly, this sixth century text, also known as the *Ādhārakārikā*, is authored by a South Indian Vaiṣṇavite Guru, Ādiśeṣa, known more popularly as Patañjali, the legendary incarnation of Viṣṇu’s serpentine companion and the famous author of multiple important Sanskrit works. That Abhinavagupta based his 10th-century śaiva text on this early work suggests not only that there was a shared corpus of texts between the North and South, but also a shared philosophical and practical basis among the numerous traditions then present in Kashmir.

As Silburn points out, this unifying basis was the Sāṃkhya -Yoga system. Ādiśeṣa’s PS is essentially a Sāṃkhya text overlaid with Vaiṣṇava theology. It borrows the classic Sāṃkhya dualism of contentless consciousness (*puruṣa*) and materiality (*prakṛti*), while reframing it in the context of Viśiṣṭādvaita.

The Trika-kaula as a Tradition of experience (*anubhavasampradāya*)

While Abhinavagupta’s PS is clearly an adaptation of this earlier text, we would be unwise to follow Chatterji’s lead in labeling it as “only the *Ādhāra-Kārikās* with a few alterations here and there.” In fact, only a quarter of Abhinavagupta’s 105 verses directly parallel the Ādiśeṣa text. The remaining three-quarters are an expression of Abhinavagupta’s own Trika-Kaula system and have no direct counterpart in the older text. For this reason Abhinavagupta states that his purpose is not simply to transcribe the *Ādhārakārikās* verbatim, but to elucidate them in “accord with the tenets of Trika-śaiva philosophy.”⁴

Interestingly, taking into account the frequent double intentionality of Tantric “twilight language” (*sandhā-bhāṣā*), this same verse can also be understood to mean that Abhinavagupta has written the PS “in accord with [his] yogic intuition of śaiva doctrine.” The crucial word in the text is *drṣṭi* (*√drś*, “to see”). Chatterji translates it as a synonym of *darśana*, or philosophical system,⁵ while Barnett renders it as “mystic vision.”⁶ Certainly, these are not mutually exclusive renderings, but rather equally valid and important translations of *drṣṭi*.⁷ Taken together, they reveal an essential feature of Indian philosophy: namely, its direct relation to direct experience (*anubhava*).⁸ In other words, in the context of Indian philosophizing, “spiritual vision” is often the logical precursor to a “philosophical system”; consequently, one’s own direct experience (*anubhava*) is a necessary and logical prerequisite to the writing of a philosophical

treatise. Hence, we are to interpret Abhinavagupta's use of the word "dṛṣṭi" as a conscious attempt to appropriate its polyvalency. In other words, his intention is to show that his capacity to elucidate the principles of śaiva philosophy (darśana) resides precisely in his own yogic perception (dṛṣṭi) attained through sādhanā.

This interpretation would clearly be in line with Abhinavagupta's own epistemological views that direct experience (anubhava) forms the apex of the three-fold means of correct knowledge (pramāṇa), whose base is scripture (āgama) and the word of the guru (yukti).⁹ Indeed, Abhinavagupta considers Tantra to be a "tradition based on experience" (anubhavasampradāya).¹⁰ Thus, the significance of the third verse of the PS is not only that it establishes the text's relation to an older scripture, but, more importantly, the author's own attainment.¹¹ For this reason, Abhinavagupta's Trika-Kaula deserves to be viewed not solely as fuel for the fires of philosophical abstraction (tarkajvāla), but rather as a practical system "providing a viable means for the attainment of mokṣa."¹²

Abhinavagupta as adhikārin

In the final chapters of his *Tantrāloka*, Abhinavagupta narrates the special circumstances of his birth. Desiring to parent a siddha, or perfected being, Abhinavagupta's parents—Narasimhagupta and Vimalā—performed an esoteric ritual. Consequently, when Abhinavagupta entered the world nine months later he was viewed not as an ordinary child, but as a yoginībhū, a special child conceived from the union of a siddha and a yoginī during the course of Tantric ritual. Due to the extraordinary circumstances of his birth and the rich devotional environs of his childhood, Abhinavagupta readily acquired mastery of a wide array of subjects ranging from Buddhist doctrine to śaiva Tantra, to grammar and poetry. However, according to

Abhinavagupta, the apex and culmination of learning came through his "studies" with the Kaula guru, Śambhunāth. It was from this teacher that Abhinavagupta received initiation into the esoteric Kula lineage. In this initiation he received the descent of power (śaktipāta) which produced a condition of embodied liberation (jīvan-mukta).¹³

Regardless of the authenticity of this autobiographical account, the fact that Abhinavagupta is compelled to narrate it in his magnum opus, the *TĀ*, suggests the prominent status of Tantric practice in his philosophical thought. As if compelled to justify his qualification for composing the *TĀ*, an authoritative synthesis of Tantric doctrine and practice, Abhinavagupta asserts that his authority lay in the very fact that he is quite simply a product of Tantra. Tantra is not something he learned solely from books, but is a practice that radically conditioned his birth and, later, produced his final enlightenment. In other words, in no uncertain terms Abhinavagupta is stating, "This doctrine is not simply something I have thought about; rather, it is a reality I have become." Logically, then, his emphasis is not on providing intellectual stimulation, but on transmitting his own experience and knowledge (jñāna). For this reason, he states clearly that his duty as a teacher is to awaken his disciples.¹⁴

Ultimately, as Müller-Ortega, points out, Abhinavagupta's teachings are to be seen as a method of realization leading to a state in which one "becomes something that moves in the Heart (hṛdayaṅgamībhūta)".¹⁵ This state of inner absorption is something that, as Abhinavagupta himself points out, transcends the limits of language and for this reason the scholar attempting an exegesis of the Trika-Kaula, is bound to confront an intriguing hermeneutical challenge. Addressing this matter Müller-Ortega asks rhetorically:

Can we completely hope to understand Abhinavagupta?...[In attempting do so] [W]e immediately encounter an important and central cross-cultural perplexity. We have been using the term understand in its commonly accepted denotation: to have a thorough technical acquaintance with something. The term may be used in a stronger sense: Abhinavagupta distinguishes between an understanding that is purely intellectual, and one gained from experiential knowledge. There is an important sense in which to understand the Heart actually requires replicating the journey of return that is the tantric sādhanā: we must play Śiva's game to its most serious and hilarious conclusion, which is the unmasking of Śiva within ourselves.¹⁶

As Müller-Ortega himself points, this type of radical understanding challenges the traditional paradigms of western scholarship. Still, the scholar of Tantra ought not ignore the fact that much of Tantric thought stems from and is geared towards contemplative experiences. In other words, much of Tantric thought is properly classified as pertaining to the realms of spiritual practice and its concomitant experiences. Does this mean that we should accept Frits Staal's bold assertion that to understand practice-based ritual traditions the scholar himself must learn the logic of its practice?¹⁷ Abhinavagupta's unequivocal answer would be "yes".

However, Abhinavagupta's views would perhaps not fare well in the post-enlightenment environs of 21st-century academia. The deeply entrenched demand for scholarly distance and objectivity perhaps does not allow for the kind of full-bodied engagement that Abhinavagupta demanded of his own students. However, the equally important demand for hermeneutical accuracy necessitates a proper contextualizing of Abhinavagupta's system. In other words, although as scholars we may feel duty-bound

not to practice sādhanā, we are obligated nonetheless to be sensitive to the practice-based nuances of Abhinavagupta's densely coded writings.

This is not to say that pure philosophical inquiry has no place in the PS for such a statement would be far from the truth. Abhinavagupta's stature in Indian history is primarily due to his great gift for verbal expression. In a way unparalleled by any one prior to him, he was able to formalize the numerous esoteric streams of Tantra into a single, unified river of thought and practice. On this grand achievement Kamalakar Mishra writes:

Abhinavagupta presents the otherwise difficult philosophy of Tantra in a cogent and coherent way that makes the Tantric position logically and rationally acceptable. What is complex in Tantra becomes simple in his treatment; what is esoteric and mystical becomes rationally understandable.¹⁸

Abhinavagupta's cogent systematization stems from his own initiation and training in the various lineages and philosophical schools (sampradāya) of his time. In other words, Abhinavagupta's philosophy is not the product of a single line of thought; rather, it is a rich synthesis of the multiple indoctrinations he pursued during the years of his own sādhanā. In his person, the plethora of Tantric schools were united through the intensity of his own critical insight and fused into a single system in which the practices and philosophical views of the various schools were grouped as a hierarchy of ascending powers culminating with the esoteric branch of Āgamic Tantrism known now as Trika-Kaula, "The Family of the Triad".¹⁹ And it was this ability to unify the plurality of Śaivism into a single doctrinal system that makes Abhinavagupta's work so intriguing. Before his time, there was no single tradition. Rather, as Alper has pointed out, there were only "a series of overlapping preceptorial lines,

and a plenitude of spiritual techniques available to each teacher.”²⁰ Hence, it was through Abhinavagupta’s teachings that these numerous techniques and lineages were subsumed within a larger theoretical framework that embraced them all. And it is this carefully crafted framework that is now commonly referred to as Kashmir Śaivism.²¹ Although, historically speaking, there never was a Kashmir Śaivism, the fact that scholars now look at the traditions of Kashmir as a unified whole is due largely to Abhinavagupta (perhaps, then, the appropriate term would be “Abhinavagupta-ism”). For this reason no text better captures Abhinavagupta’s gift-for-synthesis than the *Paramārthasāra*. A careful study of this brief yet dense text enables us to unpack the many levels of teachings and techniques he received and thereby appreciate the way in which he fuses them into a single Tantric “river”.²²

This introduction to the PS is intended to guide the reader through the multiple initiatory streams that Abhinavagupta himself journeyed in the course of his *sādhana*. In this way we can come to see that these streams-of-revealed-thought-and-practice were viewed by Abhinavagupta as ultimately united in a larger river-of-divine-consciousness that itself flows from and returns ever again into the infinite sea of radical freedom. The key to successfully charting this voyage lies in identifying the PS as a map for this most majestic of journeys. This text’s purpose, as Abhinavagupta clearly states, is to guide the aspirant through the ascending levels of consciousness until there is the realization of one’s identity with the Highest Purpose (*paramārtha*). It is along this route to the final destination that Tantric aspirant, or *sādhaka*, ontologically encounters the various philosophical systems as inner states of consciousness and being. In other words, in the initial stages of *sādhana*, when one’s consciousness is still mired by dualistic thought patterns (*dvaitavikalpa*), the teachings of the dualistic scriptures (*dvaitāgama*) are necessary. However, as one advances in

sādhana, one’s internal ascension is paralleled externally by initiation (*dīkṣā*) into scriptural traditions which claim to grant states of non-dual awareness. Hence, in the external world there is a plurality of teachings and spiritual techniques. Yet, in the inner life of the *sādhaka* these distinctions are fused in a process of internal bodily ascension.

To understand the mechanisms of this ascension we must first come to grips with the central philosophical systems embedded in the PS and the principle tenets that undergird Abhinavagupta’s thought. Constructing these tenets as our boat, we will then be ready to explore the vast, mysterious waters of *sādhana* that Abhinavagupta charts in the latter third of his treatise on the Quintessence of the Highest Purpose.

The Tantric Streams

Abhinavagupta’s Tantric Trika-Kaula ‘river-system’ is a careful re-channeling of four scriptural streams. One stream is the ancient Āgamic Śaivism, itself fed by three smaller tributaries based, respectively, on dualism (*dvaita*), dual-cum-non-dualism (*dvaitādvaita*), and non-dualism (*advaita*). A second stream is the *Pratyabhijñā* which receives its currents from both Āgamic waters and from the philosophical tributaries of Vedānta. The third stream, the *Spanda*, is similar to the *Pratyabhijñā*, in that while its source is the Āgamas it then branches off on a different course before being redirected by Abhinavagupta. The fourth stream appears to be fed not only by the Āgamas, but from various sources ranging from Tamil Nādu in the South to Nepal in the North. This poly-sourced stream-of-revelation is the Kaula tradition with its emphasis on radical antinomian practices (called “left-handed”, *vāmācāra*) as a means to immediate salvation. Of the many Kaula streams, there are two that flowed directly into Abhinavagupta’s system: the goddess-centered cults of the *Krama* and the *Trika*. Apparently, Abhinavagupta experienced the Kaula waters as the most

satisfying, for he claimed the Kaula to be the pinnacle of all traditions. And of the many streams that fed the Kaula system, he saw Trika as the greatest. In his words, Trika was to the Kaula as fragrance to a rose—its finest essence.²³ Hence, Abhinavagupta proclaimed his philosophy to be Trika-Kaulism. As we have seen, this Trika-Kaula river results from the confluence not just of the Trika and Kaula, but from the Āgama, Pratyabhijñā, and Spanda streams as well.

Commencing The Journey into The highest purpose

The opening verse of the PS crystallizes the Trika śaivas' paradoxical conception of the Śiva, the Trika-Kaula Absolute. Here, Abhinavagupta honors Śiva as the “one without beginning” who “dwells manifoldly in secret places” as “the receptacle of all.”²⁴ In other words, for the Kaśmīrī Tāntrikas, the Absolute is simultaneously one and many. Endowed with unlimited power (śakti), the Supreme Principle can manifest itself infinitely without losing its essential unity. For this reason, the universe, though appearing divided, is really only the flashing forth (ābhāsa) of the One. Abhinavagupta writes (PS 4-5):

This sphere (aṇḍa, cosmic egg) ...is brought forth by the Lord through the bestowal of his innate power and might. This universe with its succession of manifold bodies, organs and worlds is within these spheres; and therein is the enjoyer, the embodied Śiva who assumes the condition of creatures.

In other words Śiva contains within Himself the ability to manifest distinctions within unity (bhedābheda). Yet, just as a crystal remains untainted by the various hues it adopts, so the Absolute remains one despite its appearance in the form of “gods, humans, animals, and plant-life” (PS 6).

The process of universal manifestation is

elaborately explained by the Trika system through the doctrine of the thirty-six evolutes or tattvas. The supreme reality—called Paramaśiva, Para Samvit, Caitanya—is pure consciousness beyond the sphere of manifestation. In reference to its transcendence Abhinavagupta refers to the Absolute as the “thirty-seventh tattva” in the TĀ.²⁵ Yet, this transcendent principle is also the ocean of consciousness out of which creation arises. For unlike the Vedāntin conception of Brahman as static consciousness, the Trika Śaiva absolute embodies both consciousness (caitanya) and dynamism or spanda-śakti. Acting as an inner pulse, the spanda-śakti unfolds the universe of tattvas within the body of the absolute (PS 10). Hence, in the Trika schema, the transcendent contains the manifest. And even during the time of cosmic manifestation, the supreme principle (para-tattva) remains “free of delusion, pure, peaceful and beyond creation and dissolution” (PS 11).

This capacity for internal self-manifestation is explained through a dialectic of illumination and reflection (prakāśa/vimarśa). Indeed, the Absolute is characterized as being endowed with these two principles (prakāśa-vimarśa-śakti). The Absolute embodies not only an illuminating consciousness, but also a reflective capacity for self-knowledge that plays out on all levels of manifestation. At the cosmogonic level, prakāśa is the first tattva, the śivatattva, and vimarśa is the second, the śaktitattva. These two, śiva and śakti, are understood to be the Lord (īśvara) and his consort, devī. In Tantric cosmogonic schemes the union of Śiva and Śakti gives rise to creation; and in a philosophical context the union of these two principles is the fusing of a knowing agent (pramātr) with the means of knowing (pramāṇa) which necessitates the need for a source of objective knowledge (prameya). Hence, in cosmogonic terms the prameya is the very universe itself, for the product of the union of śiva and śakti, prakāśa and vimarśa, pramātr and pramāṇa, is the additional thirty-four

tattvas that form the basis of objective manifestation.

The key to understanding Trika-Kaula discourse is to realize that the prakāśa-vimarśa dialectic plays out at all levels of reality. Another way to say this is that each of the lower tattvas incorporates within itself those tattvas that precede it. Hence, even the lowest tattvas, the elemental substances (pañca-mahābhūta), contain within themselves the essence of the tattvas from even the most subtle stages of creation. Hence, the principle of illumination (prakāśa) and self-reflection (vimarśa) are present at all levels of creation. In other words, all objects (prameyas) are constituted of prakāśa and vimarśa and for this reason Abhinavagupta claims that the knower, the means of knowing, and the object known comprise a triune Self. It is in this spirit that the Tantras state that there is nothing that is not Śiva.²⁶ Hence, the world itself, when properly understood becomes a basis for mystical realization. Indeed, the higher states of sādhana are said to consist in the awareness that the world itself is composed of the bliss experienced in yogic samādhi.²⁷ There is, in other words, no need to meditate in caves: the highest realization can just as easily be apprehended while doing such mundane things as sipping chai (Indian tea).

Abhinavagupta gives a potent metaphor for this extrovertive samādhi in his comparison of the relationship of the universe to the absolute with that of reflected images to a mirror:

Just as the images of a town, a village, and other objects reflected in a mirror appear inseparable from the mirror yet appear distinct both from one another and from the mirror, in the same way, arising from the absolute consciousness of Para Bhairava, this universe, though inherently void of divisions, nevertheless appears internally apportioned and distinct [from Para Bhairava] (PS 12-13).

In this multilayered metaphor there are three

important elements: the objects (nagaragrāmādi), the reflections, and the mirror itself (darpaṇa). The relationship between them reveals both the fundamental principles of prakāśa and vimarśa and the key to understanding śaiva yoga. The mirror itself is Śiva, or pure illumination (prakāśa). Possessing within itself the capacity for revelation (vimarśa), the mirror contains a variety of reflected images. In terms of epistemology, these images are the prameya. The fact of their reflection, which is the means of their being perceived—hence known—, is the pramāṇa, and the mirror is the metaphorical knower (pramātr).

What is the relationship between the three? The answer to this question is more nuanced than it first appears. On a surface level, the reflected images appear distinct both from one another and from the mirror. In other words, according to conventional reality, one would consider the knower, the known, and means of knowing all distinct. However, as Abhinavagupta states, conventional understanding has no basis at the level of the Supreme Truth (PS 27). For this reason, the true relation of the three is stated to be one of inseparability (avibhāgin). Developing this theme of inseparability, Abhinavagupta goes on to equate the mirror with the absolute consciousness of highest Bhairava (vimalatama-parama-bhairava-bodham) who, both in terms of the metaphor and Trika cosmology, is the supreme knower (pramātr).

Now, what is the relationship between Bhairava and the universe? Abhinavagupta answers that despite the appearance of being mutually apportioned and distinct (vibhaktamābhāti), the relationship of Bhairava (pramātr) to the universe (prameya) and its reflection (pramāṇa)—like that of the mirror to its objects—is one void of distinctions (vibhāgaśūnyam). In other words, from the highest perspective, the trinity of epistemological and cosmological principles is

a unity. Like the various forms of candy, which are but modifications of syrup, these three are but modifications of the Supreme Self (PS 26).

Bondage And Embodiment

The purpose (prayojana) for writing the PS is clearly established by Abhinavagupta in the third verse where he explains that his treatise (śāstra) is written in response to the pleas of a disciple caught in the “wheel of suffering that begins with dwelling in the womb and ends with death.” Living in a universe that is inherently devoid of distinctions, being the self-manifestation of omnipotent consciousness, how then can there be an occasion for bondage? Abhinavagupta answers that this condition paradoxically arises as the result of the absolute’s power of freedom (svātantrya-śakti). In other words, it is precisely because Paramaśiva is unbounded that He/She/It can assume the condition of bondage.

In terms of cosmic emanation, the cause of bondage arises at the level of the sixth tattva (māyā-tattva). At this level, Consciousness is said to assume the capacity of self-limitation (saṅkocana) which makes possible the appearance of duality and multiplicity. The māyā-tattva is itself composed of five sheaths (kañcukas) which limit the functioning of the five powers (pañca-śakti) of the Pure Order (śuddhādhvan) (PS 16). What results is the formation of the ‘three taints’ (trimala) which encase consciousness and transform it into a limited soul (PS 24).

This limited soul is the twelfth principle, the puruṣa-tattva. In verse sixteen Abhinavagupta refers to the puruṣa as a “fettered beast” who, due to the influence of māyā, has contracted from the condition of pure consciousness (bodham) to that of a tainted soul (malinas). At this level of the cosmic hierarchy, the Supreme Self, “due to its associations with the darkness

of ignorance comes to perceive Itself as a wondrous diversity of subjects and objects.” In other words, at the level of the puruṣa-tattva, there is a perceived split between self and other.

And at this stage there unfolds the twenty-four material categories of the classical Sāmkhya schema, beginning with prakṛti and progressing through the threefold psychic instrument (antahkāraṇa)—intellect (buddhi), ego (ahaṁkāra), and mind (manas)—, the organs of knowledge (buddhīndriya)—the ear (śrotra), the skin (tvak) the eye (cakṣus), the tongue (rasana), and the nose (ghrāṇa)—, the organs of action (karmendriya)—speech (vāk), hands (pāni), feet (pāda), anus (payu), generative organ (upastha)—, the five subtle elements (tanmātra)—sound (śabda), touch (sparśa), color (mahas), taste (rasa) and smell (gandha)—, and, lastly, the physical sphere (sthūla-viśayas) constituted by the five material elements (pañca-mahābhūtas)—sky (nabhas), wind (pavanas), fire (tejas), water (salila) and earth (pṛthvī) (PS 19-22).

The result of this process is that consciousness takes the form of a body (dehabhāva) (PS 23). In other words, according to the Trika, the final result of cosmic manifestation is embodiment. Hence, in this system, the body is both the product of creation and the receptacle of manifestation itself. Hence, the body contains within itself each of the thirty-six tattvas, and for this reason reflects the structure of the universe.²⁸ Consequently, the tattva schema is to be understood simultaneously as a map of the universe and of the human being--the two, in Tantric circles, being inseparable.²⁹

As we will see below in my translation of Abhinavagupta’s Paramārthasāra, in the practices of Trika sādhana the homologies between the universe and the body play out on several levels. According to Abhinavagupta’s Śaivism, the body itself is not the cause of bondage. It is the final product of Paramaśiva’s expansive power (unmeṣa-śakti). The true

source of bondage is the malas which encase the finite soul (puruṣa, anu) in ignorance (avidyā) and create the experience of cyclical existence or saṃsāra. In such a condition, the limited soul, “like a spider with its web, spins for itself a variegated pattern by means of association with the body, breath, perception, thought, knowledge and the expanse of ether” (PS 32). In other words, while governed by the malas, the tattvas are an apparent source of bondage:

When the multitude of tattvas are unagitated the Lord likewise appears still; likewise is He excited when they are so and bewildered when there is the state of bewilderment. However, in actuality, from the [perspective of the] Highest Truth He is not these conditions (PS 38).

The last line of the above verse is the key to understanding the Trika conception of bondage. It suggests, that ultimately, the entire notion of limitation is a cosmic joke, or play (līla). In the final analysis, Śiva is never bound, and in the moment of this re-cognition (pratyabhijñā), the sādḥaka is awakened. At that point, the body becomes the temple of god (devagrha) and delusion is shattered. Then, there is the condition of embodied liberation (jīvan-mukta). Hence, for the Trika śaivite, death is not a prerequisite for final release (videha-mukta).³⁰ Knowledge alone is necessary, for in the moment of awakening there is the understanding that Śiva alone unfolds the drama of bondage and release:

He (the sādḥaka) would free his own Self from bondage by means of the splendor of the greatness of self-knowledge. Thus, the Supreme Śiva unfolds the drama consisting of the wonders of bondage and liberation. (PS 33).

Paradoxically, this moment of re-cognition, this condition of knowing, often requires ritual practices (karman) to produce a condition of purification in which pure knowledge can arise.

Consequently, the Trika sādḥana system enjoins the combining of knowledge and action (jñāna-karma-samuccaya-vāda) as a means to freedom. In defense of this position, the Trika defines the absolute as constituted of a triadic power: will (icchā), knowledge (jñāna), and action (kriyā).

The dimensions of sādḥana

Trika theology describes this world as the self-manifestation of an omnipotent and dynamic consciousness. Logically, then, as we have seen, bondage is an impossibility, an illusion or mirage. Yet, there is the experience of suffering and consequently the need for a method (upāya) which brings about the dissolving of the mirage of ignorance. Herein, enters the essential features of Tantra—an elaborate technology of self-release based on a science of the body (dehavidyā). Within this system, abstract philosophical inquiry as found in the initial sections of the PS, forms part of the means to liberating knowledge (jñāna).³¹ In other words, descriptions of the tattvas, the nature of the cosmogonic process, etc., serve not only to satisfy intellectual curiosities, but to finally produce an existential awakening and release. And this condition, the Tantras declare, requires “active ritual participation leading the aspirant to experiential knowledge (bhāvanajñāna).”³²

Hence, for the initiated sādḥaka, the PS is to be understood not as representing a philosophical stance to be agreed or disagreed with, but as a guideline for acquiring experiential knowledge that was disseminated within guarded circles of initiation and secrecy. Initiation was understood to be the sine qua non of proper textual exegesis, since it was only through this consecration that the malas could be removed. Through dīkṣā came the descent of power (śaktipāta) which made possible the revelation of the Self. “As the face is revealed in a spotless mirror,” writes Abhinavagupta, “so This (Self) is revealed as light in the mind

purified by śaktipāta (PS 9).”

This initiatory transmission was believed to awaken the aspirant’s own dormant power, the kuṇḍalinī-śakti, which, when awakened arose through the central current (suṣumnā-nādi), purifying the latent tendencies (samskāras) and uniting the sādḥaka’s limited identity with that of cosmic identity situated at the crown of the head in the saḥsārā. This path of internal ascension was called the upward yoga (udmukhyayoga) and was considered the distinctive feature of the Kaula school. In mythological terms, the upward path was the upward face of Śiva’s five-faced icon (pañcamukha-liṅga). This path removed all ignorance and established the sādḥaka in the highest state of empowerment through the shredding of the malas:

***As the chaff surrounding the rice grain
seems inseparable and yet is removed, so
this (=the trimala) is shed by the upward
yoga of the path of Śaivism (PS 18).***

For one to enter the path of upward yoga, the essential prerequisite was the meeting with a qualified master (satguru). Contact with the teacher was understood to produce an alchemical process of transformation that liberated the disciple from all impurities (PS 17). Under rare circumstances, the empowerment received from the guru was so intense (atītivra-śaktipāta) it would produce instant enlightenment and the sādḥaka would become “Śiva Himself” (PS 96). More often, however, liberation occurred gradually (karmamukti) through “ascending the steps of the ladder [of tattvas]” (PS 97).

For a fuller understanding of this process of ascension one can benefit by turning to other texts, both primary and secondary. Quality work in the field of Kashmir Śaivism is now quite established, thanks particularly to scholars like Alexis Sanderson and his kula in the UK, the many American scholars working in the field (Lawrence, White, Skora, Muller-Ortega) as well as a host of Indian paṇḍitas,

including Timalsina, Dyckowski, Mishra and others. In particular, one ought to read the Tantrālokā and Tantrasāra in which Abhinavagupta maps out the path to liberation as a fourfold means (upāyacatuśyayam) in which advanced ritual techniques are understood to correspond to the sādḥaka’s own internal state of cognitive development.

Towards this end one can also reflect on the following translation of the Parmārthasāra, in which I have attempted to capture both the literal power and poetic sweetness of Abhinavagupta’s reflections on the quintessence (sāra) of the highest (parama) purpose (artha). While this brief text does not provide the detail of other works by Abhinavagupta, it nonetheless distills the essence of his spiritual brilliance. Practiced in its own context, the Parmārthasāra is chanted as litany to a ritualized and meditative visualization practice through which the initiate seeks to re-cognize her own identity as the highest purpose (for the objectivized “goal” is inevitably one’s own subjective “self” in Trika-Kaulism). In this state of refined self-awareness, purpose (artha), aim (artha) and truth (artha) are all grounded in that Supreme Being who is one’s own self-of-self. With this awareness firmly established, the sādḥaka realizes that, indeed, “I alone am the Deity I worship” (śivo’ham)

(Dr. Jeffrey S. Lidke is Associate Professor and chair of the Department of Religion and Philosophy at Berry College. He is a prolific writer on the yoga, theme of aesthetics, spirituality and Tantra. He is co-editor for the Southeast Review of Asian Studies. This paper is a transformation and revision of a previously unpublished draft of his M.A. thesis first submitted to the University of California, Santa Barbara in 1996.



Art and Cosmology in India

Prof. Subhash Kak

The best way to understand India is through its art and the cosmology. Textbook narratives often overlook the synthesizing principles that represent the grammar of Indian culture, and they are much like the accounts of the six blind people who encountering an elephant describe it as wall, spear, snake, tree, rope, and fan, respectively.

The three notions that underlie Indian culture are that of bandhu, paroksa, and yajña. Bandhu is the binding between the outer and the inner that makes it possible to know, and this is the basis of the pervasive spirituality in India; paroksa is the recognition that the bandhu must lie outside of rational system, leading to the distinction between the 'higher' science of consciousness and the 'lower', rational objective science; yajña is transformation that the individual undergoes by participating in Vedic 'ritual' or any other creative process. The cosmology related to this framework is that of infinity and recursion across scale and time.

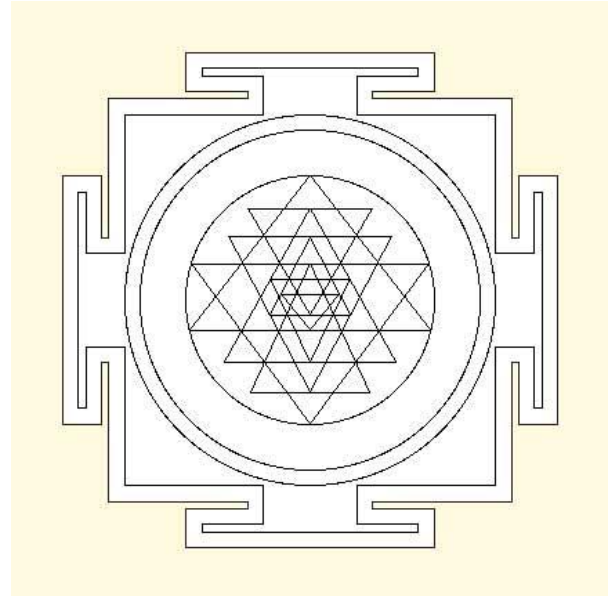


Figure 1. Sri Yantra, which represents the universe recursively

The iconic representation of the universe as the Sri Yantra (Figure 1) shows recursion most clearly. First, the tripartite division into earth, atmosphere, and the sun, which is mirrored in the individual by the body, the breath, and the inner lamp of consciousness, is represented by three triangles. Second, within each triangle are lower hierarchical levels of two other triangles, of alternating opposing polarity that represents male and female principles. All together, this adds up to 9 triangles, which through their overlaps constitute a total of 43 small triangles. Right through the middle of this is the dot, the bindu that is Shiva, the Witness, or Consciousness. Nature evolves according to law (rta in Sanskrit), but it has a paradoxical relationship with the consciousness principle.

Art associated with this conception must communicate recursion, paradox and oppositions concerning ordinary experience of the universe. Aesthetics, as a philosophy of art, is best understood from the point of view of dhvani, which communicates, by suggestion, the universals of the outer and inner worlds. Indian thought highlights the connections between these two worlds, and its art presents visions of the cosmos. Thus in Figure 2, a north Indian temple, recursion is expressed in terms of the

tower drawn to different scales on the superstructure.



Figure 2. A north Indian temple showing recursion in its outer structural form

Within the temple, the manifestations of the Supreme Being are as the One and its many forms. There exists in them, for example, a hierarchical order of cardinal and peripheral images in relation to the centre, a balancing or pairing of polarities, and representation of the temple as Mount Meru, the centre of the universe. The polarities represented iconographically related to female and male, asura (demon) and deva (god), left and right, body and mind, and so on. Aesthetics is *alamkara shastra*, that is ornamentation of the central synthesizing principle by means of the particular medium. The poet, *kavi*, is the inspired seer who sees the underlying vision most clearly. Dance, painting, and sculpture, just like poetry, have their canonical ideals, which are the visual equivalents of meter, rhyme, alliteration and the tropes of poetry.

The ritual is organized as sacred theatre that engages the senses to facilitate an epiphany that represents an experiential 'rebirth'. Great art has the same capacity, and often it is a part of ritual. Not only is the temple a work of art, so is the sculpture that goes into it, and the dance and music performed in its hallways, and the paintings that hang on its walls. One can contrast this with Western conceptions. The cosmology is finite, with God separate from the individual; art is best seen in the sterile atmosphere of the museum or the gallery.

General equivalences

The view that the arts belong to the domain of the sacred and that there is a connection between them is given most clearly in a famous passage in the *Vishnudharmottara Purana* in which the sage Markandeya instructs the king Vajra in the art of sculpture, teaching that to learn it one must first learn painting, dance, and music:

Vajra: How should I make the forms of gods so that the image may always manifest the deity?

Markandeya: He who does not know the canon of painting (*citrasutram*) can never know the canon of image-making (*pratima lakshanam*).

Vajra: Explain to me the canon of painting as one who knows the canon of painting knows the canon of image-making.

Markandeya: It is very difficult to know the canon of painting without the canon of dance (*nritta shastra*), for in both the world is to be represented.

Vajra: Explain to me the canon of dance and then you will speak about the canon of painting, for one who knows the practice of the canon of dance knows painting.

Markandeya: Dance is difficult to understand by one who is not acquainted with instrumental music (atodya).

Vajra: Speak about instrumental music and then you will speak about the canon of dance, because when the instrumental music is properly understood, one understands dance.

Markandeya: Without vocal music (gita) it is not possible to know instrumental music.

Vajra: Explain to me the canon of vocal music, because he, who knows the canon of vocal music, is the best of men who knows everything.

Markandeya: Vocal music is to be understood as subject to recitation that may be done in two ways, prose (gadya) and verse (padya). Verse is in many meters.

Some of the early meters range from the gayatri with 3 sections of 8 syllables ($3 \times 8 = 24$) to anushtubh ($4 \times 8 = 32$), viraj ($4 \times 10 = 40$), trishtubh ($4 \times 11 = 44$), and jagati ($4 \times 12 = 48$). These appear to be connected to the astronomical number 360, the number of civil days in the year. There are also many other more complex meters, with a less obvious astronomical basis.

To understand the principle behind the broader equivalences of Indian art and its cosmology, it is good to begin with the fire altars of the Vedic period that were themselves designed to represent astronomical (outer) as well as inner knowledge. An assumed equivalence between the outer and the inner cosmos is central to the conception of the temple, which is why numbers such as 108 and 360 are important in its design.

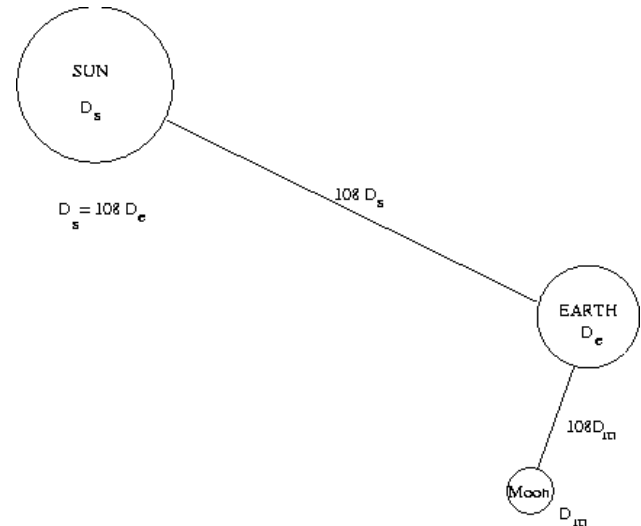


Figure 3. The number 108 in the distance from the earth to the sun and the moon

The number 108 represents the approximate distance from the earth to the sun and the moon in sun and moon diameters, respectively. (The diameter of the sun is also 108 times the diameter of the earth, but that fact is not likely to have been known to the Vedic rishis.) This number of dance poses (karanas) given in the Natya Shastra is also 108, as is the number of beads in a rosary (japamala). The 'distance' between the body and the inner sun is also taken to be 108, so that the number of joinings is 107. Not surprisingly, the number of marmas in Ayurveda is 107. The total number of syllables in the Rigveda is taken to be 432,000, a number related to 108.

The number 360 is taken in the Ayurvedic texts to be the number of bones in the developing fetus, a number that fuses later into the 206 bones of the adult. The centrality of this number in Vedic ritual is stressed in the Shatapatha Brahmana.

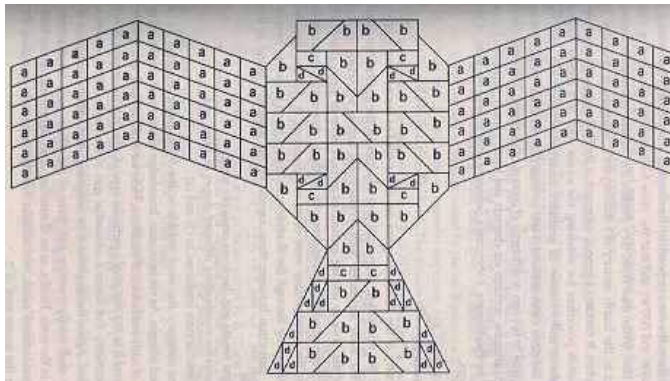
The primary Vedic number is three, representing the tripartite division of the physical world into the earth, the atmosphere, and the sky and that of the person into the physical body, the pranas, and the inner sky.

The Vedic altars had an astronomical basis related to the reconciliation of the lunar and

solar years, which mirrors the reconciliation of the female and male currents within the body and mind of the individual. The fire altars symbolized the universe and there were three types of altars representing the earth, the space and the sky. The altar for the earth was drawn as circular, whereas the sky (or heaven) altar was drawn as square.

The fire altars were surrounded by 360 enclosing stones, of these 21 were around the earth altar, 78 around the space altar and 261 around the sky altar. In other words, the earth, the space, and the sky are symbolically assigned the numbers 21, 78, and 261. Considering the earth/cosmos dichotomy, the two numbers are 21 and 339 since cosmos includes the space and the sky.

The main altar was built in five layers. The basic square shape was modified to several forms, such as falcon and turtle. These altars were built in five layers, of a thousand bricks of specified shapes. The construction of these altars required the solution to several geometric and algebraic problems.



0.....

Two different kinds of bricks were used: the special and the ordinary. The total number of the special bricks used was 396, explained as 360 days of the year and the additional 36 days of the intercalary month. Two kinds of day counts: the solar day, and tithi, whose mean value is the lunar year divided into 360 parts.

Three different years were considered: (i) nakshatra, or a year of 324 days (sometimes 324 tithis) obtained by considering 12 months of 27 days each, where this 27 is the ideal number of days in a lunar month; (ii) lunar, which is a fraction more than 354 days (360 tithis); and (iii) solar, which is in excess of 365 days (between 371 and 372 tithis).

A well-known altar ritual says that altars should be constructed in a sequence of 95, with progressively increasing areas. The increase in the area, by one unit yearly, in building progressively larger fire altars is 48 tithis which is about equal to the intercalation required to make the nakshatra year in tithis equal to the solar year in tithis. But there is a residual excess which in 95 years adds up to 89 tithis; it appears that after this period such a correction was made. The 95 year cycle corresponds to the tropical year being equal to 365.24675 days. The cycles needed to harmonize various motions led to the concept of increasing periods and world ages.

The number of syllables in the Rigveda confirms the textual references that the book was to represent a symbolic altar. According to various early texts, the number of syllables in the Rigveda is 432,000, which is the number of muhurtas in forty years. In reality the syllable count is somewhat less because certain syllables are supposed to be left unspoken. The organization of the Rigveda is also according to a plan, but that is a different story told in my book *The Astronomical Code of the Rigveda*.

The verse count of the Rigveda can be viewed as the number of sky days in forty years or $261 \times 40 = 10,440$, and the verse count of all the Vedas is $261 \times 78 = 20,358$.

The Brahmanas and the Shulbasutras tell us about the altar of chhandas and meters, so we would expect that the total Rigvedic hymn count of 1017 and the group count of 216 have particular significance. Owing to the pervasive tripartite ideology of the Vedic books we

choose to view the hymn number as 339×3 . The tripartite ideology refers to the consideration of time in three divisions of past, present, and future and the consideration of space in the three divisions of the northern celestial hemisphere, the plane that is at right angle to the earth's axis, and the southern celestial hemisphere. The number 339 is simply the number of disks of the sun or the moon to measure the path across the sky: π times 108 is approximately 339. The Rigvedic code then expresses a fundamental connection between the numbers 339 and 108. The numbers 108 and 360 appear as the axis and the perimeter dimensions of the temple.

Temples and gods

The temple is considered in the image of the Cosmic Purusha, on whose body is displayed all creation in its materiality and movement. Paradoxically, the space of the Purusha (Rigveda 10.90) is in the sanctuary only ten fingers wide, although he pervades the earth.

The outer cosmos is expressed in terms of various connections between the temple structure and the motions of the sun, the moon, and the planets; the inner cosmos is represented in terms of the divinity (universal consciousness) in the womb of the temple and various levels of the superstructure that correspond to the states of consciousness. The position of the gods in the Vastupurusha-mandala within the temple is a symbolic representation of the spatial projections of the cosmic Purusha in his body. There are other iconic representations of sacred space, as in the Sri Yantra where the body's three parts – vagbhava, madhya, and mula – have recursive structures within, that represent Vedic cosmology in a unique fashion.

The prototype of the temple is the Agnikshetra, the sacred ground on which the Vedic altars are built. The Agnikshetra is an oblong or trapezoidal area on which the fire altars are

built. During the ritual is installed a golden disc (rukma) with 21 knobs or hangings representing the sun with a golden image of the purusha on it. The detailed ritual includes components that would now be termed Shaivite, Vaishnava, or Shakta. In Nachiketa Agni, 21 bricks of gold are placed one top of the other in a form of shivalinga. The disk of the rukma, which is placed in the navel of the altar on a lotus leaf is in correspondence to the lotus emanating from Vishnu's navel which holds the universe. Several bricks are named after goddesses, such as the seven kritikas.



Figure 5. Ganesha: elephant-headed, wise, with mouse as his vehicle

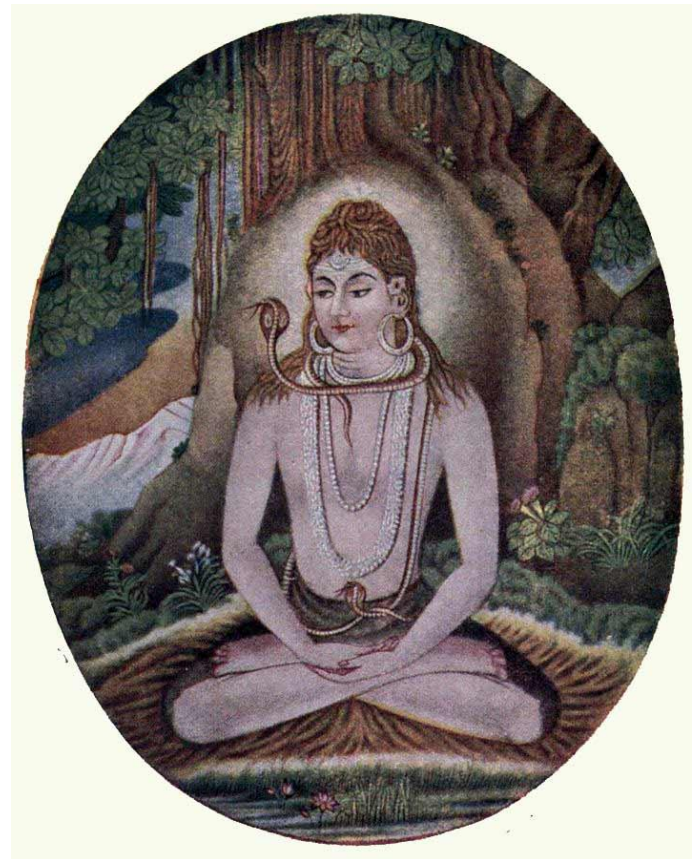
The Hindu temple represents the Meru mountain, the navel of the earth. It is the representation of the cosmos both at the level of the universe and the individual, making it possible for the devotee to get inspired to achieve his own spiritual transformation. The purusha placed within the brick structure of the altar represents the consciousness principle within the individual. It is like the relic within the stupa. The threshold to the inner sanctum is represented by the figure of Ganesha (Figure 5), who, like other divinities, symbolizes the transcendence of oppositions.

The temple construction begins with the Vastupurusha mandala, which is a yantra, mostly divided into 64 (8×8) or 81 (9×9) squares, which are the seats of 45 divinities. Brahma is at the centre, around him 12 squares represent the Adityas, and in the outer circle are 28 squares that represent the nakshatras. This mandala with its border is the place where the motions of the sun and the moon and the planets are reconciled. It is the Vastu in which the decrepit, old Chyavana of the Rigveda 1.116.10 asks his sons to put him down so that he would become young again. Chyavana is the moon and Sukanya, whom he desires, is the sun.

In the basic Vedic scheme the circle represents the earth and the square represents the heavens or the deity. But the altar or the temple, as a representation of the dynamism of the universe, requires a breaking of the symmetry of the square. As seen clearly in the agnichayana and other altar constructions, this is done in a variety of ways. Although the main altar might be square or its derivative, the overall sacred area is taken to be a departure from this shape. In particular, the temples to the goddess are drawn on a rectangular plan. In Shiva or Vishnu temples, which are square, change is represented by a play of diagonal lines. These diagonals are essentially kinetic and are therefore representative of movement and stress. They embody the time-factor in a composition.

The Hindu temple, as a conception of the astronomical frame of the universe, serves the same purpose as the Vedic altar, which reconciled the motions of the sun and the moon. The progressive complexity of the classical temple was inevitable given an attempt to bring in the cycles of the planets and other ideas of the yugas into the scheme. There was also further complexity related to the expansion of the tattvas within the temple. For example, in Shaivite temples we see the unmanifest (Shivalinga) expand into the intermediate state of manifest-unmanifest (Sadashiva), and finally into manifest (Mahesha).

The Ashtadhyayi of Panini (5th century BC) mentions images. Ordinary images were called pratikriti and the images for worship were called archa. Amongst other things we are told that a toy horse is called ashvaka. (This means that the queen who lay down with the ashvaka in the Ashvamedha did not sleep with the dead horse.) Deity images for sale were called Shivaka etc., but an archa of Shiva was just called Shiva. Patanjali mentions Shiva and Skanda deities. There is also mention of the worship of Vasudeva (Krishna). We are also told that some images could be moved and some were immovable. Panini also says that an archa was not to be sold and that there were people (priests) who obtained their livelihood by taking care of it. They also mention temples that were called prasadas.



Shiva

Complementing the tradition of the Vedic ritual was that of the munis and yogis who lived in caves and performed austerities. From this tradition arose the vihara, where the priests lived. The chaitya hall that also housed the

stupa may be seen as a development out of the agnichayana tradition where within the brick structure of the altar was buried the rukma and the golden man.

The gods are the entities that hold up the inner sky of the mind. There is the single Brahman or Purusha, interpenetrating and transcending the inner and the outer universes. But the framework of the inner sky is held up by a variety of gods. The physical nature, governed by laws, is the Goddess or Shakti. If Brahma is the deity of the astral world, Shiva is that of the physical world, and Vishnu that of the causal or the moral world. They each have a consort: Brahma's is Sarasvati, the goddess of learning and the arts; Shiva's is Parvati, the goddess of power, energy, and intuition; Vishnu's is Lakshmi, the goddess of good fortune.

The gods themselves are interconnected. Brahma's origin is from the lotus in Vishnu's navel. Shiva is the god who subsumes all oppositions. He is the celibate, divine yogi, who is also the perfect husband to Parvati. He brings the world to an end by his dance, but he also creates the world. He is the heart of consciousness, the lord of all beings, the divine dancer. As Ardhanarishvara, he is half Shakti; as Harihara, he is half Vishnu.

Vishnu is the all-pervader, the primal person, without beginning or end. He is also known as Narayana, with his abode in the waters. He is Hari, the golden-garbed one (like the Sun), and his mount is Garuda, the eagle. During the periods in between dissolution and creation, he sleeps on the cosmic serpent Ananta (the endless). He wields in one of his hands the discus, Sudarshana, which represents time. His consort, Lakshmi, appeared out of the Churning of the Ocean. Periodically, he descends to earth as an avatara to battle evil. Two of the most popular of these avatars are Rama and Krishna.

Churning of the ocean

If extraordinary experience is an epiphany, it comes at the end of long preparation. In myth, we speak of the struggle between the asuras (demons) and the devas (gods), but this struggle also occurs within the individual between his materialistic and acquisitive tendencies that are demonic, and those of sacrifice, compassion, and understanding that are divine. This struggle is described as the churning of the ocean by the gods and the demons as in Figure 7. On the axis rests the Goddess, who represents Nature. Note that the demons are shown with animal faces since they represent our animal selves.



Figure 7: The churning of the ocean

Our body sense is much stronger than the sense of spirit. It is for this reason the asuras are generally much stronger than the gods. The story goes that the gods have been defeated and they are dejected. At some point they go to Vishnu for help and he suggests that they should assist the asuras in the churning of the ocean of milk, out of which will appear the nectar of immortality that would help them subdue the asuras.

The gods and the demons got together and started churning the ocean with the Mount Mandara as the axis and the snake Vasuki as the rope. The gods were at Vasuki's tail while the demons were at his head. Vishnu appeared as a tortoise to support the revolving mountain. As the churning went on, many gifts appeared including the moon which Shiva decided to use as an ornament on his head. Next came Dhanvantari, carrying a jar full of nectar. Next

arose Lakshmi, with her attendant elephants of the four quarters sitting on a lotus, a gift of the ocean. She went straight to Vishnu.

The demons were dismayed that Lakshmi had not come to them, and they stole the jar with the nectar that was in Dhanvantari's hands. But before they could drink it, Vishnu created an illusion of the most beautiful woman, Mohini, and they were so bewitched by her that they did not notice that she took the cup from their hands and gave them to the gods to drink. By the time they knew what had happened the gods had become immortal. The demons drew their weapons and attacked but it was useless. The gods once again became rulers of the three worlds.

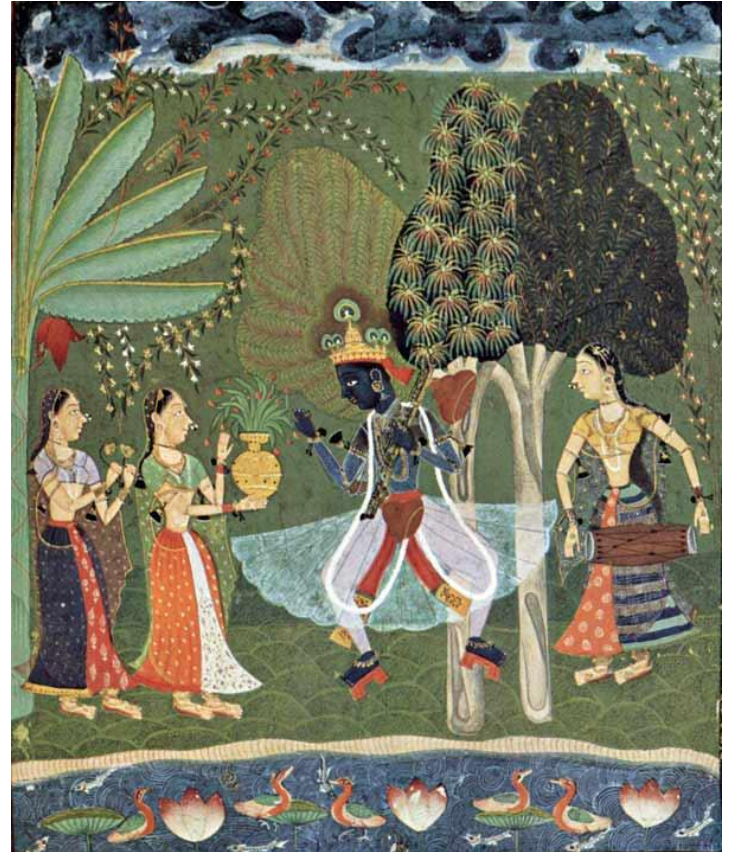


The asuric individual is doomed for he gets distracted by the illusory Mohini, whereas one who has higher ideals finds immortality and fame (Lakshmi).

Krishna's dance

Krishna's pranks and the love that the cowgirls (gopis) have for him is the frame for much of poetry, dance, and painting in India. As avatara of Vishnu, he is the narrator of the Vedic wisdom in the great dialogue of the Bhagavad Gita. His cowherd stories are a take-off on his other name Gopala, which means the protector of the world as well as cowherd, for the root gauh means both earth and cow.

The story of the love of the gopis is the story of each devotee for God. Krishna performs the rasa-lila, a dance, where mysteriously he is able to simultaneously dance with all the different gopis, which represents, no doubt, the mystery that the same One is able to inhabit the many.



Dancing Krishna with his flute

Krishna, the flute player, is the spirit that inhabits each one of us. The flute is the body, and the melody is the unfolding of our individual lives. The love of Radha for Krishna can never be fulfilled, since the individual is forever doomed to stay apart from the divine in ordinary experience.

In the Mahabharata, Dhritarashtra is the ego, Vidura is discriminating intelligence, the Kauravas are the physical desires, Krishna is the transcending atman, Arjuna is the empirical atman; the higher faculties are the Pandavas, and the lower faculties are the Kauravas. The characters of the epics and the Puranas do not only act in the outer world; they play out our own private battles.

In the Ramayana, Sita is the intuition who has been abducted by the demon within, who must be set free by Rama, the inner sun. The demon, representing the urge to dominate and possess, has ten heads that represent the sense and action organs of the body. In the struggle between the asuras and the gods, Hanuman, representing the human mind that has devotion, provides critical assistance.

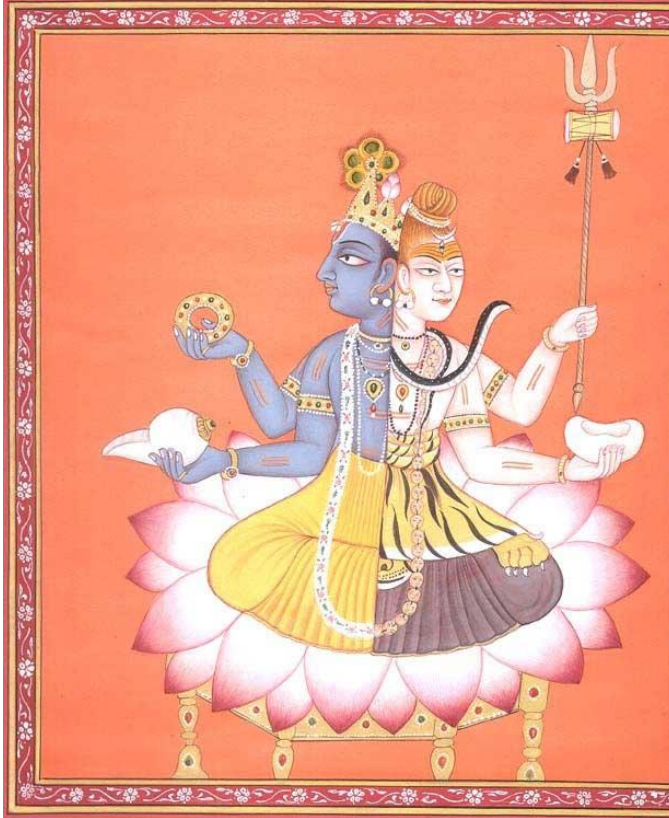


Figure 10. Harihara: Vishnu and Shiva as one

Although Vishnu and Shiva make their appearance generally in different situations since their centrality is in different domains, they are also visualized in a unity, as Harihara (Figure 10).

The Indian approach to reality is to seek a harmony that balances materiality with the spirit. It is this harmony that is the main goal of the artistic creation, and we see it expressed not only in the sacred arts, but also in music and dance.

The Indian aesthetic in an age of war

We live in an age of war fueled by conflicting visions of reality. The mainstream cultural view is of materialism in which consciousness is an emergent process and we are primarily nothing but our bodies. Perhaps because it belittles the spirit, it is leaving many young with a sense of hopelessness. If there is nothing transcendent about life, then life may not be worth living. While some are choosing drugs or hedonism, others are rejecting rationality and joining cults. Religious leaders are stepping in with their own recipes to save the world from a soul-less hell. But their conceptions contradict each other, and although they rightly critique the materialistic paradigm for its disconnect with the spirit, they themselves remain focused on the body when they speak of everlasting life in paradise.

Because of the mechanization of life and the expectations raised by images with which we are bombarded by the media, many are choosing not to have a family, leading to a demographic crisis in the developed world at a time when the post-industrial service economy needs more workers and consumers, requiring vast numbers of immigrants from poorer countries. These are some of the elements leading to a clash of civilizations.

The Indian way offers a different perspective. Indian cosmology is not in conflict with science, although it does speak of the domain of spirit that lies beyond language and rational science. It makes claims regarding the nature of consciousness and transcendent states of awareness that are so extraordinary that if they should be validated by science, they would change the way we conceive of reality.

Our collective history in recent decades has tilted too much to material prosperity. The Indian way is not to reject the body, but to find a harmony between body and soul. To deal with the inevitable march of the machine and the dangers of totalitarianism of one sort or another, it provides intimations of other layers of being that lead to compassion and self-control. It

opens up new vistas that shift the focus from being to becoming.

The Puranas have a charming story about how the gods came to become invincible, even though they started out as the weaker party. Shukra, the priest to the asuras, discovered, through science, the secret of reviving persons who had been killed in battle, and with this knowledge the asuras were able to subdue the gods. Brihaspati, who is the priest to the gods, recruited his son, Kacha, for obtaining this knowledge. Kacha presented himself to Shukra asking to be taken in as student. Even though he sensed danger in this, Shukra was helpless because one cannot turn away anyone who is seeking instruction.

Before long, Shukra's daughter Devayani fell in love with Kacha. The asuras were alarmed and they killed him on two occasions, but on his daughter's pleadings Shukra revived him. The third time the asuras not only killed him, but ground his body into powder and mixed it with the wine that they offered to Shukra. When Devayani found that Kacha was missing, she pleaded with her father for help and with his powers he found what had really happened. But this time he could not just revive Kacha within his belly because that would cause his own death. He had to first teach him what the secret of restoring life was so that when revived, he would bring back the dead Shukra to life. This done, Kacha returned with the secret knowledge to the gods, who again became ascendant.

The coming together of spiritual India and mechanical modernity is like the coming together of Kacha and Shukra that can only be good for all mankind. With wisdom, it should be possible for people, irrespective of their cultural and social background, to live together with compassion and harmony in pursuit of a way of life that values freedom and personal creativity.

References

Kak, S., 2000. The Astronomical Code of the Rgveda. Munshiram Manoharlal, New Delhi.

Kak, S., 2002. The Gods Within. Munshiram Manoharlal, New Delhi.

Kak, S., 2002. The Asvamedha: The Rite and its Logic. Motilal Banarsidass, New Delhi.

Kak, S., 2003. The Prajna Sutra: Aphorisms of Intuition. LSU, Baton Rouge.

Kak, S., 2004. The Architecture of Knowledge. CRC/Motilal Banarsidass, New Delhi.

Kak, S., 2005. Early Indian art and architecture. Migration and Diffusion, vol 6, 2005, pp. 6-27.

Kak, S. 2006. The axis and the perimeter of the Hindu temple. Sangama, 2005/2006.

(Prof Subhash Kak is a Regents Professor and a former Head at Computer Science Department at Oklahoma State University at Still water who has made tremendous contribution to Cryptography, Artificial Neural Networks, and Quantum Information. He has also researched and published widely in the field of Indology, Ancient Astronomy, History of Science and Philosophy of Science)

Physics versus metaphysics

(Correspondence between Dr.Sisir Roy and Paranand Swami)

Respected Swamiji,

Niraj Kumar told me about you and your writings in the Newsletters.I am delighted to read some of your articles on Rhythm, cosmic Dance etc".

I tried to communicate to you through gmail but it bounced. I requested Niraj to talk to you about some matter related to 'vibration" or "spanda" from scientific point of view which I have already written in my last mail..

Since vibration can not be thought of as a-temporal or a-spatial and without the existence of the medium, we scientists face the problem of understanding.I will be delighted if you enlighten me in this regard.

Warm regards,
Sisir roy

Swamiji:

Blessed self,

The problem of understanding lies with the view point . The scientific process is purely objective and quantitative it can hardly explain any mystic, supernatural or extra spatial phenomena. A metaphysical perspective is deficit in quantitative inference and can be of a very little or no scientific authenticity . If a quantum physicist were also to be a gentleman of some mystic bent and vice versa both would also like to go subjectively and qualitatively about this phenomenon . Let me give you a tantrik semiotic semblance of the quantum vacuum and an iota of electric charge that scientists discovered on it . In an absolute void , atemporal as you call it there is a very minute charge that accrues from the mystic process of shiva getting condensed as Shakti the primeval

energy that denoted dynamism within the shell of perfect vacuum or shiva

There union is signified by the fourth vowel which is realised as the eternal word by yogins of great spiritual accomplishment .

वियदीकारसंयुक्तं वीतिहोत्र समन्वितं अर्धदुलसितं
देव्याः बीजं

सर्वार्थसाधकं

The void I.e. ह is comparable to quantum vacuum

र the fire or energy when unites with it I.e.

after.a fraction of the chidakash or the conscious space been condensed is into the form of energy . With nada which is a latent form of vibration this great tantrik encryption has all the mystery of the power and process of the universal phenomena embedded in it .

Instead of an insentient vacuum our ancient seers conceptualized or realised the existence of a conscious ether चिदंबरम who is capable of contracting himself in the form of energy or Shakti and who further accounts for the process of spanda or creative divergence .

Respected Swamiji,

I am delighted to get your response. However, the issue is precisely the following :

(1) The concept "spanda" seems to be a kind of "vibration " of "kincit chalan" a throbbing. This creates the phenomenal world. This has a striking similarity with the concept of fluctuation of quantum vacuum.

Swamiji'reply

There is an interesting resemblance between ancient orthodox energy definition of Spanda and your specification . We consider spanda as a sentient vibrant entity which pervades the or rather embraces the entire universal phenomena and at the same time transcends it . This is similar to the mind charge that quantum physicists recently observed whin quantum vacuum.

हंतानंतस्फुरत्ता जयंति जगति सा शांकरी
स्पंदशक्तिः

The author of spanada Karika defines spanda while felicitating it ,as shiva power of oscillation . Now given that shiva is comparable to quantum vacuum I.e the zone of zero objectivity Shakti or to more precise spanda Shakti of shiva is the primordial divergent creative impulse that manifests in the form of three conditionings viz Time ,space and substance continuum . I have added substance or वस्तु to this continuum because in our ancient canons the infinite as subjective consciousness has three fold conditioning or अनंत as conditioned in time is called eternity or absolute time . Ananta can also be defined as subjectively conscious quantum vacuum with zero objectivity this on being conditioned in space is defined as अखण्ड or the spatial substratum . The absolute universal principle as per the Upanishadic power and process of universal manifestation generates grosser material manifestation of ether ,air ,fire water and earth and then pervades these in such a manner that he interlaces these without any actual modification . Then there is the process of divergence according the attributes of these five basic constituents of the universal phenomena namely sound as that of the ether sound and touch as the attributes of air ,sound ,touch and sight of fire and sound ,touch ,sight ,and taste as the four attributes of water .

Your hunch or let's call it intuitive insight just falls in with such notions in our ancient revelations regarding spacetime continuum. besides these two the third "Substance- conditioning " of the absolute principle is also considered in our ancient texts . Space or Akash in its subtle most form is not just a medium which might as well be absent in the parlance of quantum vacuum but the space transcendent subjectively conscious substratum . Shiva as the guru or supreme preceptor has been felicitated as व्योमवत् व्याप्त देह I.e. Manifesting as the omnipresent ether or

चिदाकाश . As per the notion of chidakash it must pervade even quantum dot or quantum vacuum which as I figure out is the line of demarcation between actual and intellectual notion . Substance is added as the third condition since the original subtle notion of ether is akin to what quantum science understands as quantum vacuum . We have a description of five gradations of subtlety in the tantric canons .being the subtlest and most pervasive ether is contained in solid ,fluid,energy ,and dynamic manifestation of nature the fifth form of Akash is called (चिदाकाश) or conscious ether .this is the twilight zone of mind matter juncture . The gross ether as a part of the gross penta-dimensional phenomena ,the subtler ether as subtler ether that pervades the rest of the four elements ,chittakash or the ether that pervades individual intelligence comprising cognitive,volition,imaginative and self determining faculties . The subtle most or chidakash or conscious ether exhibits similar characteristics of QV . If this चिदाकाश by any stroke of chance turns out be also pervading quantum vacuum owing to space transcendent nature of the both . Mind and energy as the primordial building brick of the universal phenomena can be consistent from either perspective I.e physical as well spiritual .

Dr.Roy

Why this fluctuation in vacuum ? We assume that Quantum Principle is valid everywhere - not only in phenomenal world. So according to Heisenberg Uncertainty principle, there will be enormous fluctuation of energy during a very short period of time.

Swami Ji's reply

Heisenberg is right in his own place but is this just an arbitrary behaviour of insentient matter or the design of highly ingenious nature of the supreme being ?

The agency that accounts for this fluctuation or let's say spanda in the eternal still quietude of

the sentient ether or cidakash is in fact the process of Shiva manifesting as Shakti. This divergent outflux or spandanam is the second succession of modification, the first being the atman creating ether the second step is air or rit springing forth from the primordial ether.

The nearest parallel of "quantum " in the parlance of consciousness specially when it comes to subjective consciousness has been called sphota स्फोट in our metaphysics .Like energy, consciousness also propagates in the form of small units or packages termed as Quantas and sphota respectively .Ancient seers conceptualised this process as pertaining to expressible word I.e either a syllable or word or sentence .

Energy शक्ति in this context is defined as the power of consciousness that accounts for the relation of word with its meaning . This semblance leads us to the consistency of quantum physics principles in the realm of consciousness .

Awareness as such manifests in the form of word and meaning which are known as nad नाद and बिंदु (nada being the point of absolute convergence of collective word and Bindu the point of absolute convergence of collective meaning) .**Eastern metaphysics emphasises on the Nada aspect whereas modern science focuses on the notion of Bindu, objectively though .**

Sisir Roy:

(2) Concept of Quantum Vacuum : Various type of fields are there and hence concept of space time is there.

(3) My hunch is that space time itself is generated by this fluctuation.

But we do not really understand this process?

Swamiji's reply

As I have said above your hunch just falls in with the Upanishadic dictum regarding the power and process of the creation or let us say the manifestation of the universal phenomena .

...from this self I.e. Pure subjective consciousness ether springs forth from the ether air and from ether air(tattiriya upanisad)

If the ether were to be compared to quantum vacuum then the secondary manifestations air or dynamism and energy follow . The " will to create " interlaces all the following varieties of grosser manifestation . As another Upanishad Antaryami Brahman goes ... **“one who interlaces ether knows ether but whose ether doesn't know ,one who indwells air who knows air but whom air knows not”**

These are the ultimate postulations by our hoary seers in a parlance of mind matter relationship . We must conceptualise matter as insentient and the underlying streamline of consciousness as pervading various gradations of subtlety and grossness of matter and accounting for their respective characteristics . These are based on intuitive insight and not on scientific observation therefore these are assimilated better through faith and devotion .

Shri Aurobindo writes in his synthesis of yoga – “energy in the power and process of creation is matter and spirit in the power and process of creation is mind” . Off late there has been a sort of innovation in the post shankarite monism to ignore all other schools of thought as meant for less competent and extrovert aspirants . So all talks of insentient matter converting into living protoplasm stand refuted. The conscious substratum must be preconceived which before converting into dynamic perpetuation or spanda out of still a temporal void or vacuum exerts his own free will .

स्वस्मिन् स्वात्म स्वभित्तौ कलयति
धरणीमाशिवांतं जगद्या

हंतानंतस्फुरत्ता जयतिजगति सा
शांकरीस्पंदशक्तिः

(propitiatory verse of spand karika)

Within the canvas of her own conscious substratum she creates this universe consisting of thirty six elements from earth to shiva .

From the stand point of quantum physics it IS may be too early to conclude anything but from an eastern metaphysical perspective the divine will of the universal being accounts for this mystic phenomena of spanda .

This is the very nature of the lord but how can a complete and content being have any wish to manifest or procreate?

देवस्यैषस्वभावोयं आप्तकामकामस्य का स्पृहा
(Gaud padacharya)

Sisir Roy:

(4) May be here lies the mystery of "spanda".

(5) Concept of ānda" or ěgg" principle is considered in Indian Philosophy.

I think it is a metaphor - like Hiranyagarbha or "tathagatagarbha" in Lankavatar sutra.

Sometimes I wonder why this metaphor of "garbha" or "womb" was introduced.

Can you enlighten me in these issues ?

Swamiji's reply

As per the Indian law of causation the effect cannot supersede the cause so even with all its reciprocations the objective phenomena cannot transcend the substratum which is the pure subjective consciousness Which as you define is a temporal and time transcendent entity .

The expanse of the lords vision is same whether the universal phenomena is completely extant or it is when it is dormant in a seed form ,one canon on tantric metaphysics says .Hence the analogy of the yolk of an egg or a womb . The Veda propound an intermediate stage that predates actual creation as hiranyagarbha or the golden womb .

Hiranyagarbha manifested in the beginning The creator of all beings and their lord . He sustained the earth and the heavens ,to him do we offer oblations (rikveda)

When the a priori of creation is an existent entity we call it the golden womb or hiranyagarbha . When the ultimate is required to be pronounced as essencelessness or nisvabhavata then we call it tathagata garbha . But the basic idea is the same .

The maxim of the yolk of a peahen egg is popular among the Shaivites of Kashmir
मयूरांडरसन्यायः न्यायः . All colourful beauty of the plumage tuft and feathers of a peacock are dormant in the yolk of its egg . Apparently it looks only a white colour less jelly with a lump of yellow mass . **Like wise within the quantum vacuum or perhaps the concept of QCD the chromodynamic blue print of creation may be encrypted in a dormant seed form .** The quantum chromodynamics phenomena may be a projection of some more discreet design of future manifestation embedded in the sub nuclear realms . The semiotics of a peahen egg just befits the context .

It would be a great break through if the string theory of electronic physics could be related to the ancient concept of सूत्रात्मा -a fine filament

of living energy or प्राण which pervades the individual subtle body and the cosmic subtle body or hiranyagarbha .

I hope this philosophising is of some use to you

Yours in the lord .

Swami paranand tirth .

Sisir Roy:

Swamiji could you please throw some light on the 4th mantra of Isavasyasyopanisad and concept of 'Maatrisva'.

Swamiji's explanation:

In this particular mantra of Isavasyasyopanisad, Tamsin -within him , refers to the conscious and subjective space or chidakash. This concept falls in with the notion of quantum vacuum except that there is no scientific proof of its being a subjectively sentient entity as of now . There are two entities mentioned in this mantra आप and मातरिश्व instead of using the dictionary, meaning "water" I chose to define it as "fluidity "dynamic flow which is similar to अप and मातरिश्वा .we have two other Vedic mantras which rule out these two as insentient material entities . One is from Brihadaranyaka it says ता आप ऐक्षत the waters cogitated and another mantra from rikveda containing the term matarishwa which sayanacharya interprets as मातरि आकाशे श्वयति श्वसिति इति

मातरिश्वा (an entity which respire in the conscious ether)

The crux is that both fluidity or aap and dynamism or matarishwa are sentient

modifications of a sentient ether or chidakash . No fluctuation or movement can ever exceed the domain of their substratum hence these are contained within it . This is where scientific advancement and mystic insights meet.

My wavelength is more in tune with Upanishadic and tantrik thought therefore I defined aap as fluidity and matarishwa as dynamism.the primordial divergent flutter or spanda may be reflected in the phenomena that accounts for the manifestation of electrical charge (aap and matarishwa) in quantum vacuum.

The other day I was watching a video of group discussion ,One eminent scientist called all this "spooof- physics " being construed to vindicate hackneyed metaphysics,This doesn't have to be so with ingenious scientists like you who also have a bent for our metaphysical heritage . And therefore also trying to tie up the loose ends accordingly .

Yours in the lord

Swami paranand tirth .

Sisir Roy:

Respected Swamiji,

I am delighted to get your response regarding the meaning of the word

"maatarisva" in Mantra 4 of Isopanisad.

You say :vacuum is fluid dynamic.

This is very interesting from the point of view of modern physics.

In modern cosmology we say that the universe is originated from the fluctuation of Quantum vacuum.

Now when you say fluid dynamic : why you say fluid instead of saying simply space;

If we decompose this word into two parts :
maatri and svas ;

maatri is related to mother means measure. So we can say space is the substratum of measure or distance because unless there is measure or simply distance. you can not create any form.

One can think of the principle of Maya at the very beginning also. Again the word maya is related to ma or to measure. Whenever you say measure, it means limitation and hence illusion created about the ultimate reality. I read somewhere that "maatarisva" means space which breathes i.e. in our terminology we say fluctuation of space.

Why this fluctuation - because of the existence of Heisenberg uncertainty principle in quantum theory.

According to this principle, during very short duration of time, there will be huge fluctuation of energy which gives rise to the universe.

Now very interesting question comes :

Whether space itself fluctuates or the existence of certain kind of fluctuation of fluid, makes the space fluctuation occur.

I will be delighted if you explain me why you choose fluid.

Warm regards,

sisir roy

Swamiji:

Blessed self

I have also included the word अपः that precedes matarishwa . Both have

A special type of dynamism is common I.e. A temporal displacement .

Fluid, as one of my dictionaries defines it is a substance subject to continuous deformation under some pressure or force . Vayu or spirit has no form and flows continuously motivated by the power of will or action or knowledge . ज्ञान इच्छा and क्रिया , so I thought fluid and fluidity was more conveying . If one reflected on the first half of the mantra

तद्वावतो अन्यान्यत्येति तिष्ठन् it tells us about the fluctuation within the substratum of a static vacuum . An extra temporal displacement !

I deliberately chose the term fluid or Fluidity because it denotes primordial movement in the still and stagnant ether or to be more precise the conscious ether .In the arcane tantrik ontology this is defined as Shakti tatvan.

The. Just movement cannot explain any supra temporal displacement .

This is more efficaciously explained in Pratyabhijna Hridayam as the

Unfolding of universal phenomena within her(while referring to chiti or chitshakti) own domain which predates the manifestation of time ,space and substance .

The divine mother whom we adore as the power of consciousness spoke through the daughter of a Vedic seer in first person ..I flow like wind and generate the entire universe .अहमेववात इव प्रवाम्यारभमाणा भुवनानि विश्वा etc this a very inspiring suktam of rikveda called Devi suktam or at a suktam .

Some votaries of monism refer to this Shakti as maya or the innate beginningless delusive power of the lord and also attribute the process. Of creation to her .this concept is presumably for the less gifted ones . Real vedantist do not reject the universal as virtual or ephemeral but "maintain that it is real till it appears so .

What I mean by "fluid or fluidity is the first dynamic to modification within चिदाकाश .

There is a reasoning of the order of subtlety and pervasiveness so space as such pervades all grosser manifestations too . So instead of space or Akash I enunciated fluidity as air or energy or spirit .The nearest parallel of quantum vacuum is eastern metaphysics .

Movement according to QD is a tiny iota of energy which one scientist friend told me was discovered within the quantum vacuum . The entire power and process of creation from the absolute principle getting conditioned in the form of ether ,dynamic air or spirit, energy,plasma and finally the solid seems to be latently encrypted in the realm of sub nucleonic minuteness. In our previous communication we discussed the analogy and semblance of quantum chromodynamics and मयूरांडरसन्ध्यायः I.e. Maxim of a peahens egg.

Prana or energy i.e. The first manifestation of dynamism within a static shell as the mantra we are discussing signifies the first portion of the word सत्यम् or truth I.e. सत् which is ether and air or the invisible portion of the phenomena . The other half त्यत् signifies the perceivable phenomena

Or fire ,water and earth. The unison of these two I.e. Subjective and objective portions of the universe ,according to our Upanishadic seers is the spiritual truth . Quantum physics as it were seems to be striving for this truth, in its own way though .

Yours in the lord

Swami Paranand tirth



RISHIKESH: SILENT HUM OF MYSTERY

Ambika Talwar

With mild trepidation and a touch of enthusiasm, I agreed to write this story of my visit to Rishikesh some years ago. Moments after, it dawned on me that I could not recall much about my days in this august city of pilgrimage. I smiled: so typical of me to jump into the ring of fire and wonder what happened. *Déjà vu!* Not the visit but my habit.

So I called my mother in Delhi to ask what she recalled. Neither of us could even remember which year it was. But she tuned in and started talking. She recalled how fantastic it was that we had the darshan of Swami Chidanand Saraswati of the Divine Life Society where we had stayed. She said this was a rare thing. I recalled being ushered into the visiting room. I remember Swamiji looking at us, gesturing that I move closer...then handing me some pamphlets.

Mother spoke about the Lakshman jhoola, the temples along the River Ganga, the Shiva statue. Then she laughed saying, "That's it. No more."

Visions came alive in my mind's eye in an eidetic train of possibilities. The statues made by a German devotee for the temple, life size statue of Vishnu and Lakshmi in Vaikuntha, the divine Ganga where boats are held in place by

strong iron chains, shops selling items for *puja* in temples, restaurants...

1.

I remember how much I had wanted to visit Rishikesh among other cities. Having lived away from India for a number of years, I had developed a longing to connect in ways I hadn't when I was a child. The old wanderlust was stirred. The sacred was dancing. When I arrived in New Delhi, I insisted that we three travel north. Father loved to travel, but said no, take mother with you. Mother was keen. We left by train one early morning.

The train pulled out of Delhi station, then stalled, stopping amid fields on the outskirts of the capital. After a long hour or so torrid with smells and indecision, mother and I decided to leave the train. We found a three-wheeler, which took us to the bus stop. We reached in time for a bus towards Haridwar – the door of God.

Getting to Rishikesh would be a further challenge as finding a connecting bus was not easy. If I recall, we hired a taxi. In the eyes of the divine, what would it matter how one arrives at a destination. We might each have been told at some point that the destination

is never the goal. It is something far deeper, even if ephemeral; far more poignant, even if it calls for one to be stoic.

Journey is a celebration, a dance. It is an answer to a longing of the soul; is this not Love in all its forms? I smile for I recall being told there is something inherently poetic about being Indian, that we philosophize every little human act or decision. I have not a response.

I imagine mountaintops with wild hair of *rishis* and Mothers fanning the winds. For in the head is glowing fire.

2.

Our supposed destination is this beautiful place by the foothills of the Himalayas. We are here. I

feel physically charged and excited and wish to begin my exploration of holy sites and treasures. I think: I am here! I am in Rishikesh.

Call me not tourist

in search of fame

take away even my name

or what's a river for?

Mother and I arrive at the ashram and are shown our room. One rule mother lives by is to clean the room and bathroom wherever we land. This is a way of making it one's own. My eagerness to get out borders on impatience. Finally, we leave and walk down the slope back towards and past the *langar* (where food is served) to the temple of many rooms. The main room of this temple has statues of Mother Durga and Saraswati, each made by a devotee, who had lived here for many years. These are exquisite expressions of love. How the lines flow with dynamic grace of the Mothers who are the center and electrifier of all cosmic expressions.

The goal of journey is to find this mystery. There is much more to discover.

As we go towards the gate, a man from the temple calls out to us. We wait. He comes to us calling, "Ma." He wants to know who I am, where I am from. I feel a little shy. He brings us mangoes, my favorite fruit. His name is Dushrath. I feel his adoration and wonder about it. As we are leaving, he will hold the fruit for us. He tells us he had run away from his home in Orissa when he was around 14 years. Difficult life struggles led him here where he found peace and self. Thinking about this moment itself triggers my body with vibrations, which have become now very frequent in the last two years.

From here, we head out to town. Up and across the road, we visit the main center of the Society.

Here we meet with Swamiji. Poignant moments with him go with us to the narrow streets with vendors lined by temples and the river. How beautiful is this Ganga; this is the closest I have come to our ancient waters, source of a trillion legends.

how fast she flows

cold rush of wild

knowledge

Mother and I cross the Lakshman Jhoola to find narrow lanes, which take us to other temples. On this first day, we stay close to the central areas. But we get a wondrous view of Lord Shiva's statue, elegant against the blue sky. For a short while, we walk along the river and watch the boats neatly secured. They have to be, for the water rushes at a phenomenal speed. Swimming in here is prohibited. One has to enter the wild river holding on tightly to the chains held fast by solid iron posts, or be carried away by her passionate love.

I remember the smell of the air lifting over the river. Then I wonder. How does a mythos smell — one that has cradled a civilization for thousands of years; one whose breath has spawned poetic utterances now caught amid sheaves of paper; one that continues to inspire right thinking, one that will maintain harmony and love? I am caught in these musings again even as another devastating war is causing a deeper wound in our hearts and psyches and all life is on the alert.

How shall a timeless mythos continue to birth its new ways in the midst of uncertainty of the survival of the very species that is causing its own demise? It is not that wisdom cannot pour through technological junk as is surely evident by the diverse texts on the web, myriad impressions on film, and ways of calculations.

It is the alacrity with which corrupt beings distort the power of innovation that speeds our end and that of all species on this glorious planet.

Somehow, mother and I find our way to a temple within the confines of a wall, which is painted pink and decorated with a *swastika* at regular intervals. The boundary wall has the familiar look of cracks and mildew, which is somehow comforting. We enter through the white metal gate contained by a white wall with a scalloped arch above which is a sign in *Devanagari* that says Mani Kuta Dham. The temple inside is lovely, but I cannot recall who the deities were. What I remember are small altars on the first floor with different deities: we love our diversity of form, symbol, and attributes. The silence is sweet; we can always hear the birds. We linger inside here for quite a while.

When we depart, we see a young man sitting beside one of the *swastikas*. Curious, I begin a conversation with this traveler from Israel in search of his peace. I ask how it feels to sit by a *swastika*. He smiles for he understands its real meaning, a meaning distorted for gain and loss, a meaning that reveals ultimately harmony of the cosmos through the revolution of planets around the sun in a symbol also of the Celts, the Greeks, and indigenous peoples of the Americas.

Mother and I walk back to the ashram. She has hurt her foot, so we go slowly.

As we return to the ashram, Dushrath who had been awaiting our return brings us the luscious golden mangoes. He walks us back to our room and waits outside to walk us to the *langar*. Inside here, we find plates and sit on the floor. We are served rice and vegetables. When we eat, we wash our plates in the community

washing space, which is all wet and not so clean. Unfortunately, in the framework of making spiritual offerings, people have forgotten the care of the vehicle. Surely, body, mind and spirit must be in balance and equally cared for. Also the body outside us, the places we inhabit. But that cleaning is always left to someone else.

3.

black night lingers in dreams

let birds waken us

to majesty

of loving kindness

After a strange waking this morning, I step out to find a bowl of fruit left at the door. Dushrath and his devotion touch me endlessly.

When we leave to eat at the *langar*, he waits to walk us there. He is again excited to see me and he shows us around the temple again. He shows us his simple home. He assures me he will bring me mangoes the following day. My heart falls for we have little time in Rishikesh.

We begin our adventure along the slopes of these winding roads amid mountains whose mystery and rough beauty invites. We stop at a jewelry shop and buy *sphatic malas*, necklaces made of naturally occurring crystal beads. We stop at another shop where sits a palmist. He asks to see my palm and then makes a strange look. Mother says, we should never show our hands to strangers. I don't know what he saw; I know what I am becoming.

We continue to discover more and more temples along the river and among rich diversity of trees, wild fauna. It is their breath too that

marks the walls of temples and houses. It is not uncommon to see a new baby tree growing out of a wall. Innocently life expresses itself in myriad places where the sun shines.

Far from the main walkway amid huge trees and houses are small *kutiyas* here and there: homes for the *sadhus* whose lives are spent in prayer. Somehow holiness or a sense of it marks the bricks that walls are made of. Holy men with dreadlocks and red turbans sit on steps or by tea stalls; homeless men lie in slumber and rest under trees. Temple bells stir the air every so often. I hope commerce will not take away the rhythm of this town.

Local folk watch us with interest. Dressed much like them, I wonder why we are the cynosure of curious eyes. The chatter of people walking and temple chanting weave the spaces in which we walk.

*we are that weave
always that sings
in chaos...
a riot of colors
splinters hearts
open amid falling fruit.*

We visit old temples, some are part of old houses: it is a way of life. Just as there is no separation in true heart and mind and we (might) live in concert with nature, so, too, in the old structures that emerge one from the other set amid trees. Yes, monkeys, too, are part of the scenario. How can we be separate!

River Ganga calls us to sit beside her, but not for long. Once evening changes color, we are asked to move away from the edges. The

rhythmic lapping of water by the shore and the rushing of the river remind us to honor the silence. Mother and I wonder at the difficulties of our family: why is this condition that of the whole world? But it is how it is, they say. Our last evening here is wrought with bitter-sweetness as we reflect on passages in our lives and what yet we desire, so be fulfilled.

I celebrate her whose eyes hint at sorrow in moments when she hides behind a smile, or a song she has not sung.

4.

We carry our bags outside where Dushrath waits loyally for us. I feel already his sadness at our leaving. He insists on carrying all our bags down the street to the bus-stand. He wants to know when we will return. His tear-spiked eyes won't let go of my gaze. I do not know which Mother he saw in me. But my feeling of my own journey is renewed. I am reminded of earlier times when I felt Mother in me.

*mango is an endless road
kissed in this air
a pathless path
of devotion...
remnants of time
point to that other road
where points meet
a luminous eye.*

In a few hours we reach Haridwar. Such a crowded place that walking through the milling throng is a challenge I have not experienced in some years. In a tiny cab jostling on narrow roads in this ancient Door to God, we reach the river. Of course, it is the river where much

happens. In a few hours will be the *aarti*, waving of lights and song for blessings.

This time, I hold the chains and step into the river. Delicious and cold, the water wraps round my slender body, I breathe in a taste of glory, I feel sated now. Cold water always brings me to serenity. All around me people are waving these lights made with small *atta diyas* placed on betel leaves. These are then let go of in the river, so the blessings go far and wide. Bones of the cremated are cast in the water further downstream. Mine are still living bones, but living and dying are concurrent streams.

I come out of the water soaked to the head to the bone, wave my own *aarti* and set my desires free into the river. What will I manifest? What will I become?

5.

I return with longing for all that was stirred in me, the days when Mother sang her primordial sounds into the weaves of my body, perhaps, before I was born — this body in my own mother's womb taking on her unsung songs. My own mother who traveled with me to these shores has been wistful with her own longing.

What if we erase old symbols, icons, and tools and began anew! What if we return to our primal sound and sense and rewrite our longings with the silent hum of light and dark: pure, ineluctable, and ubiquitous.

dark eyes of Dushrath

remind I am

kiss of simplicity

interwoven mesh

of timeless wonder;

SHE dances in me

and I must be as She

wild whole potent.

Love is devotion!

In just three days, a bite of Himalayan air brings me to my hidden self. The wild hair of the sages will carry secrets of such seeds in the wind, the fire, the water, and the mountain gaze stolid in the far distance. My hair wet with Ganga water frames my face as I gaze at the flames winking in a *diya* on a plate of sown betel leaves in my hands.

Now 20 years later when I look through the internet for pictures of places my mother and I had visited, I find a wild splash of tourist attractions: water sports, beautiful yoga on the banks, eateries. Someone got it wrong. Someone wrote the wrong contracts. I wish some of these are just tags for other places, that Rishikesh still has a magic that lured me into its heart.

That which is pristine must remain so.

(Ambika Talwar is an author, healer, teacher and an artist and is currently teaching English in Cypress College)



Travelogue: Southern Sojourn (Part 2..concluding part)

Dr. Girdharilal Kaw

Next day, 18th October, we started late at 9am, as we had to go to Madurai which was not very far off from here. The road was a state highway, in good condition though single track only. After about 35 kms. we deviated from the highway to reach a small town/ village called Shanmugham. Here we were supposed to visit a Kartikeya temple on a hilltop. Our vehicle reached right up to the foothill and from here one could see the temple sitting majestically atop the mountain. Firstly, we thought that women-folk may not be able to make it to the top. A series of flights of stairs, about 80 to 100, paved with stones were awe- inspiring. All of us managed to reach the top and were rewarded with a magnificent view of the temple. It was a smaller temple but with artistically carved pillars of the Mandapam and sanctum sanctorum carved out of the rock itself was a wonderful sight. The temple is dedicated to Kartikeya, the six-faced son of Shiva and parvati. Kartikeya is called Subramanyam, Shanmugham and Murugan also in south India. The whole hill is actually a solid rock in which a small temple along with the deity has been carved out. Afterwards the mandapas must have been added to it. Here, again we were the only visitors and therefore had good time seeing everything in the complex. Moreover we were allowed to enter the Garbha-Greh also and offer

obeisance and puja. After coming out of the temple complex, we could see a bird's eye view of the whole town from above which was overwhelming.

We left the place and soon we were again on the highway to Madurai. On the both sides of the road there was plenty of greenery and a maze of mango and coconut orchards. We reached the city at about 1pm and checked in a grand old hotel called Germanus. It's old world charm with heavy wooden furniture looked magnificent. After taking lunch, and some rest at about 4pm, we left for renowned Meenakshi temple. Since it was the Diwali day in TN, markets were closed, roads almost empty and so we reached the temple in just few minutes itself.



Here we met our guide, Mr. Manikaran, just near the main entrance gate only. Mr. Manikaran was a tall pleasant young man, with the mannerisms of a Tollywood hero. His sweet Tamil-tainted Hindi mixed with a spatter of English sounded fantastic. He took us directly to South Gopuram, the main entrance to the temple complex. This is the highest tower of the complex and in structure and design almost similar to the ones in Ranganathanswamy temple, only that it is 164 ft tall. There are 14 Gopurams in all, five major ones and nine smaller ones. Meenakshi temple is dedicated to Bhagwati Meenakshi, a form of Parvati, though there is her consort Sundreshwar also in the temple. Actually, according to a legend they were married here in presence of Vishnu in an elaborate ritual.



The central shrine of the complex is of Meenakshi and the emerald hued black stone image of deity is exceedingly beautiful. Sundreshwar shrine is also nearby only and both temples have large gold plated Kalashas or Vimanam. Since there was not much of a rush we could go around all the corridors of the temple complex along with our guide without much of difficulty. The tall sculpture of Lord Ganesha just outside of Sundreshwar temple, carved out of a single stone was a wonderful sight. This is called Mukurny Vinayakar here.



The golden vimanams can be seen from a great distance in the west through apertures of two towers, again an architectural marvel. The corridors or Prakramas on both sides are endowed with majestic stone pillars with

exquisite carvings of imaginary animals, one of them called Yali, which is horse, lion and crocodile all in one. One cannot but feel proud of our glorious past after seeing such artistic excellence. The Prakrama surrounding the sanctum of Meenakshi is called Killikondumandapam- meaning bird cage corridor. This space was once used to keep green parrots in cages who were trained to utter the name of Meenakshi all the time.

Madurai, second largest city of Tamil Nadu, is rightly proud of this great temple, and is famous as a city of temples, city of cotton and city of festivals. After leaving the temple complex we planned to shop for cotton clothes. Although most of the shops were closed, we did manage to find a lone handloom shop at some distance from there. All of us did some shopping and returned to our hotel. There, the whole staff of the hotel was waiting for us to celebrate Diwali as it was already late in evening. It was a good gathering, and almost all of us enjoyed the cracker bursting and other pranks. Then after a good dinner we retired to our rooms, with the instructions that tomorrow we would be leaving for Rameshwaram. But since on 19th it was their Diwali day, we would have a brief Laxmi pooja in one of the halls of the hotel at 7.30am .

Thus on 19th morning all of us were ready by 7.30 am and gathered in a small conference hall, named Davy Hall. Our manager had arranged all the puja material and sweets etc. already. One Mr. Bhat performed the puja in a brief but traditional manner and all of us took the blessings and Prasadam from him. After that we had our breakfast and started our journey towards Rameshwaram. The road was reasonably good though narrow and one way. After driving for about three hours one could smell Rameshwaram in the peculiar fishy smell of the sea breeze. After here the road was mostly accosted by sea on both sides.

Rameshwaram area is actually a strip of an elongated land mass more of the shape of a tail, pushing into the Bay of Bengal dividing it into Gulf of Mannar and Palk bay. At one place the two seas meet through a narrow channel called

Pamban channel, over which a huge new road bridge has been constructed, where all the tourists get down for few minutes to have a nice view of the canal as well as the fishing boats. But more than anything else, one can see a railway bridge almost just under and parallel to the higher up Road Bridge. The peculiarity of the railway bridge is that it is a folding bridge which can be folded up at times to allow the ships and ferries to navigate from one to other side. This bridge was constructed during British rule and was an engineering marvel of its own time.

Soon after we reached our Hotel, namely Royal Park Hotel just on the roadside. Rameshwaram is a small town/village made famous by its world renowned Temple and a great personality of recent times, Dr.A.P.J. Abdul Kalam. After taking a little rest, we had a traditional lunch and prepared to leave for sight-seeing. Our first destination was the newly constructed mausoleum of our most popular ex-president, Dr. A.P.J.Kalam. The place was not very far from our hotel and we reached there in hardly few minutes. Actually Rameshwaram has only one main road which ends blindly at the sea shore. And all the small villages, hamlets and the main town also are situated on both sides of this road itself. The mausoleum has a simple but elegant theme befitting the personality of the great man. In fact, I have no hesitation in calling him a modern day Maharishi, who was an embodiment of the philosophy of Karmayoga, not only in his life, but in death also. He is easily the brightest son of Bharat Mata in the last century. Popularly known as the missile man of India, he was a scientist by profession, but he lived a life full of simplicity, hard work and incessant teaching. He was a born teacher, who enjoyed teaching young minds wherever he got the opportunity. In fact he died while teaching something in a town of Gowhati only. Surprisingly the place was quite busy, and just a round of the complex which is not very big took more than one hour. The clean, calm, sober and serene atmosphere of the place was soothing, to say the least.

From here we took the same road towards the sea. Just after few kms only there was one ancient, though small temple of Hanuman on the road side only, called Panch-Mukhi hanuman.



We spent little time here also and saw the floating stones, rather rocks, supposed to have been used for Setu Samduram. Again we drove about ten kms.on the same road to reach a place called Danushkodi, which is the last point of this tail of the land mass, locally called Lanka border. This hamlet has nice beaches on both sides which attracts tourist all along the year. We also enjoyed the sea breeze and shallow waters for some time and finally returned towards the main town for Rameshwaram Temple.



But in the way, we visited two smaller temples called Vibhishan Temple and Ram-Jaroka temple. Vibhishan temple is supposed to be the place where Vibhishan, the rebellious and pious

brother of Ravana was given the abhisheka before inducting him in the Ram-Sena. The Rama-Jaroka temple is situated on a small hilltop called Ganthamanthanam Parvatham- the highest point in Rameshwaram- where a foot-print of Lord Rama in front of a chakra (wheel), is worshipped by devotees.



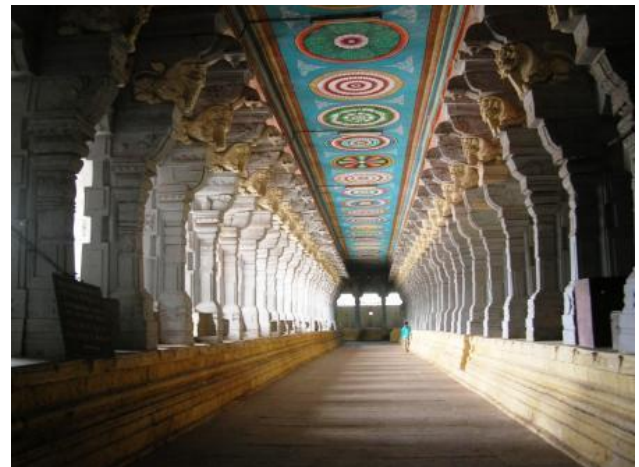
After spending some time at both the places we proceeded straight towards the main Rameshwaram Temple. But somewhere in the town we did locate the ancestral house of Dr. Kalam, where his extended family is living even today. It was a wonderful feeling.

Rameshwaram Temple is a famous shaivite as well as vaishnav temple of India. It is one of the 12 holy Jyotirlingas. According to the legend, it is an ancient temple directly linked to the victory of Rama over Ravana.

It is said that Rama was uncomfortable after killing Ravana- a Brahmin- and thus tainted with brahmhatya. At Rameshwaram, he met saint Agastya who advised him to perform the pooja of Shiva in the form of Shivlinga according to Agama Tradition. Rama asked Hanuman to bring a Shiv-Linga from Mount Kailasha, and Agastya Rishi fixed an auspicious day for the stipulated pooja. But Hanuman could not return on that day. Meanwhile, Sita had made a Shiva Lingam of sand and it was decided to perform the puja of the same lingam. Since Rama performed the puja of Lingam it is called Ramalingam also. Afterwards, when hanuman reached with two Shivlingas, Rama asked him to install one on the north side of the main lingam and second at the entrance, where

now-a-days a statue of Hanuman is also installed. Rama also declared that devotees shall first worship the one from Kailasha and then the one made by Sitaji. And even today , the sequence of puja is in the same manner. Shiva was very pleased with Rama's worship and appeared himself along with Uma and proclaimed that whosoever takes a bath at Danushkodi and then worships Shivlingam here shall be absolved of all the sins.

The place where the Lingam was installed and worshipped was known those days as Ganthanam, but afterwards because of Ramalingam became famous as Rameshwaram- the master of Rama. The present temple was built in 12th century by Pandya kings. Even Sri-Lankan kings also contributed to the shrine generously that time .Since then Temple has been renovated, extended and decorated many a times. The major contribution being of Sethupathy kings from 16th to 18th century. These days there are lots of security measures and checks to be followed to enter the main complex. It is a huge complex, consisting of three major corridors or Parikramas. But, what impresses and mesmerizes a visitor are rows and rows of majestic stone pillars on both sides of the corridors.



The sculpting of the pillars is very artistic in Nayakar style as in Meenakshi temple. Probably, the pillars are more than two thousands in number. The ceiling also is exuding grandeur in great scale. After walking down the parikramas we reached a place where we were told are 22 Kundas representing all the

holy waters of Bharat Desha. A devotee is supposed to have a bath in each of them starting from Agni-Kunda- the sea of Danushkodi. But due to the paucity of time and other reasons most of us had to be content with a spray of water from the kunda supposed to be the mixture of all of them. After this ritual we again joined a long serpentine line for the final Darshana. These days the devotees can have the darshana and worship the Shivalinga from distance only. Shivlingam is a small one and from a distance of few meters it looks even smaller. The other Shivlingam remains behind the curtain at the time of darshana.

It was already late in the evening, and we proceeded straight to our hotel for dinner and rest. We were informed that the next day would be the longest journey of the tour, as we have to reach Puducherry in the evening, and thus should start early in the morning.

Next day, on 20th October, we started early just after the breakfast, and had some refreshments after about three hours of drive at some roadside eating place. By around 1 pm we reached the famous city of Thanjavur and planned to have the lunch break here. Thanjavur is famous for its style of paintings and many temples. But the renowned Brehdeshwara temple is the biggest and endowed with exquisite architecture. The temple is dedicated to Lord Shiva. The temple has been built by a great Chola king, namely Raja Raja Chola from 1003—to 1010 AD. This place is a UNESCO world heritage site. Unfortunately, we could not visit the temple as it was closed for afternoon break and we had no time to wait because of the long distance ahead. We did see its huge fortified walls and within which a monumental temple with its majestic Vimana or Kalash standing proudly at 198ft height.

After having our lunch there, we drove straight to the city of Chidambaram, again a big city of Tamil Nadu very well known for its Thillai Nataraja Temple. The place was once called Thillaivanam, because of forests of Thillai trees. Thillai is a species of mangrove trees growing at many places near sea shores in TN. This temple

is probably the greatest Shaiva temple in TN. This is the birth place of the sculpture and bronze image representation of lord Shiva as the cosmic dancer- Nataraja- a Tamillian concept and motif in Chola art that has since become notable as a symbol of Hinduism and has inspired postures of Bharata Natyam. Nataraja dances to the rhythm of Om- Pranava Mantra, called Anand Tandava. The temple complex is spread on a huge area of more than forty six acres. There are ten holy tanks in the complex, the most sacred of them being called as Shivganga. The complex enshrines all the three Trinities- Brahma, Vishnu and Rudra a rarity of sorts. There are four entrance towers or Gopurams, all 135 ft tall, and the deity Nataraja is depicted on the South Tower, as nataraja is supposed to dance facing south.

The temple has been built in 9th century by Chola kings and afterwards extended and renovated by other kings also up to 16th century. After Cholas, the significant contribution has been of the Sethupathy Kings. A very famous Natyajali festival is celebrated here on every Shivratri. Actually, it is believed that Shiva and Parvati compete for dance here. The main Gabha-Greha has an idol of Nataraja, which is mesmerizingly beautiful- a finest example of temple art.



Just nearby there is a small but wonderful shrine of Devi Shivakama Sundari- a form of Uma. Surprisingly, we saw a small shrine dedicated to Chitragupta also here, which is not a usual accompaniment of Shiva temples.

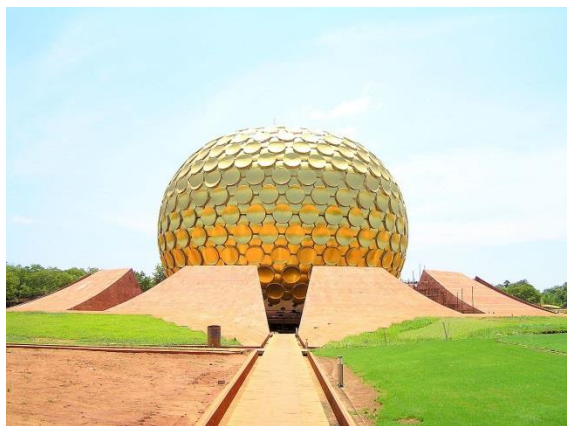
We left Chidambaram late in the afternoon, and drove straight towards Puducherry. The last

stretch of the road was very congested and we reached our hotel in Puducherry late in the evening.

On Saturday, 21st October, we started at about 9 am and left for Auroville. It was not far off and we reached in less than half an hour. The place is a vast area of wasteland turned into a leafy green lawns, orchards and shady environment. Apart from this garden like ambience, there is an edifice of spiritual significance called Matrumandir, which was our destination .

Our vehicle had to be parked somewhere near the office complex and from there it was a 15 minutes walk up to the place. For the people who cannot walk down they have their own vehicles for this stretch. Before embarking on the walk visitors are shown a video in a hall, explaining Shri Aurobindo's philosophy, Auroville and other relevant information about the place. Most of our people left by a special vehicle and three of us walked down the distance. Just before reaching near the place we saw a very aged and majestic Banyan tree with hundreds of adventitious roots acting as its physical as well as nutritional support.

Matrumandir can be seen from a distance as it is built in a large open space called Peace. The structure was started in 1971 by the Mother of Aurobindo Ashram and could be completed only in 2008, long after her demise. This unique structure is in the form of a huge sphere, surrounded by twelve petals. The whole dome is covered by golden discs which reflect the sunlight to give it a peculiar radiance.



casual visitors are not allowed to enter the

structure and have to view it from a distance or a place called “view Point”. Only the people who have booked for the meditation sessions have to enter at specific times. We were told that there is a large meditation hall inside called the Inner Chamber. The four main pillars which support the inner chamber have been placed at the four main directions of the compass and are symbolic of four aspects of the Mother Goddess as described by Aurobindo.

After returning from the Matrumandir we visited the souvenir shops near the office complex and all of us purchased some titbits and around 1pm we returned to our hotel for lunch and some rest.

In the afternoon we again left for sightseeing and our first stop was a church called Sacred Heart Basilica. It had a classical Gothic architecture and a beautiful and clean ambience around it. From here we went to Aurobindo Ashram- the main attraction of Puducherry. This ashram is the seat of a spiritual community where disciples practice a particular form of meditation and yoga called integral yoga, devised by Aurobindo himself. He reached this place in 1910 from west Bengal along with four of his companions and they started living in a small two room place, where they started their meditation regularly. Slowly the number of disciples increased and the need for the bigger place also was fulfilled.

It was in 1926, when The Mother came to live here for good that Aurobindo decided to withdraw from the public view and the management fell in the hands of mother. The Mother of the Ashram was a French citizen born to an Egyptian Jewish mother and Turkish Jewish father and named Mirra Alfassa, who had some spiritual visions and experiences right from her childhood. She came to Pondicherry in 1914, 1920 and finally in 1926 to settle in the Ashram. She managed the Ashram right up to her demise in 1978. Aurobindo passed away almost suddenly in 1951 only. At present the Ashram is located in the midst of a high end residential area, a very simple building but with so calm, clean and serene atmosphere that one

cannot but feel at peace there. The main shrine is a Samadhi consisting of a white marble structure which holds in two separate chambers the physical remains of Aurobindo and Mother, which is always covered with flowers in a tree shaded courtyard.



Disciples and visitors pay their respects to both by making a Parikrama (circumambulation) of the Samadhi. Apart from the Samadhi the whole courtyard is laden with beautiful flower beds which adds to the serene and spiritual atmosphere here. After paying our respects at Samadhi we had round of the Ashram building which houses many relics of Aurobindo's life. The most interesting part of the building is the book store which contains the books written by and about Aurobindo and his Yoga. We spent some time there and purchased a few books before we left for our next destination.

Not very far from the Ashram is a unique Hand-made paper factory. Here workers manufacture paper from rags and they readily accepted to demonstrate to us the whole process which takes place in only one large hall. Paper is then dyed and various designs are made on it before it is sent to shopping outlet, which also is in the premises only. All of us went there and purchased few articles of hand-made paper which were delightfully colored and designed.

From here we went to a famous Vinayak Temple located in a crowded street. It did not take much of a time to have the Darshana and Parikrama of the deity.

Now it was the time to head for our last destination, Rock beach of Puducherry. The whole beach has a beautiful and clean walkway which was very busy as it was a weekend evening. We also walked down the walkway for about a km. or so, as the visitors are not allowed to go down towards the shore which is full of huge crimson and blackish rocks. The sea was also a bit rough but the breeze of the Bay of Bengal was enjoyable especially when you have fresh popcorn to munch upon. Almost at the end of the walkway we saw one black granite statue of Gandhiji surrounded by a white canopy.

From there we went directly to our hotel as it was already late in the evening. On Saturday 22nd Oct. we started at 8.30am and just after two hours we were nearing the coastal city of Mahabalipuram. We were told that there are many historical monuments in this city and we would be visiting most important of them today. Soon we reached the first site called Panch Ratha, located just on the road side only. This is a recently excavated site (about sixty years) which has five monuments in a row and now named after five Pandavas, though there is no known historical or mythological connection to them. This is finest example of Monolithic architecture in the shape of processional chariots built in first half of seventh century (around 630), built by early Pallava kings. These temples are not chariots but stationary monuments. On the southern end is the biggest monument called Dharamaraja/ Yudhishtira temple is about 36ft. tall monolith with exquisite sculptures of gods, goddesses, loins, crocodiles and other animals. Even on the outer side of the temple we see beautiful sculptures of Ardhanareshwara, Harihara, Brahma, Bhairava and even Nataraja. It clearly shows the respect and faith in all the traditions of Hindu thought at that time. There is one decipherable inscription also mentioning the name of Narsimhavarman-1, an early Pallava king.

Next temple is called Bhima Ratha. It is a massive structure but seems incomplete. Needless to say that none of these temples are living temples today as most of the deities are withered or even missing. Arjuna ratha looks

most beautiful as the outer walls are carved into panels with fourteen exquisite sculptures like 4 Dwarpalas, Vishnu, A Rishi, Murugan, Shiva with Nandi and some human figures. A massive loin and Nandi are on each side of the Ratha.



Just north to the previous one is Droupadi Ratha a small, just 11 by 11 ft with a beautiful slanting roof. Sculptures of loins and elephants are conspicuous, but the shrine deity is missing. Outer walls show Durga reliefs, very delicately carved. The last Ratha is named after Nakula and Sahdev and seems incomplete and the other statues are also not very clear. A huge standing elephant is on the north east of this monument.

From here at a distance of a few kms. only was the famous Sea shore temple, called so because of its location. This temple also is a recent find only. In fact, the two tier compound wall with more than fifty sitting Nandis carved on top of it has been laid bare only after the recent tsunami of 2004. This is a Shiva temple along with two smaller temples and open halls, gateways etc. spread on a large area. The main temple is 60 ft tall, a structural temple built of blocks of granite. The inscriptions here indicate its date as 700 to 728 AD, in the reign of Rajasimha. The temple complex is a Unesco world heritage site, the main temple faces east. Its garbha greha (santum sanctorum) enshrines Main deity of Shiva linga with a small mandapa and a little space for circumambulation (Parikrama) also. A bas relief of Shiva, Parvati, Karikeya and Ganesha with Brahma and Vishnu on the sides completes the picture. In front of the temple is a Bali Peetham (Sacrificial Altar) and there is a

small Varah Temple at the basement with boar sculpture, which has been recently excavated.



Another small temple is also a Shiva temple but the third one between the two is a reclining Vishnu temple (Anantshayi Vishnu) while as the walls carved into a series of loins and Nandis. Near the compound wall there is a monolithic sculpture of a partly carved and partly sculpted lion with an open mouth, as if guarding the whole complex.

Again at a distance of just few kms. only, we reached a site of few other monuments of very large significance. The most spectacular of these is called by various names as Arjuna Penance; Decent of Ganges and Bhagirath Penance. This is a massive carved creation on two huge granite boulders. This is supposed to be of mid-seventh century. Arjuna has been shown in a posture of Dhuma yoga i.e., standing on one leg only in an emaciated but a calm and meditating condition. There are a host of gods, goddesses sages and Dronacharya on one side, as if coming for a darshana. There are many carvings of humans, animals, birds and reptiles as well. Between the two boulders and their carvings is a very enchanting figure of flowing Ganga vertically from above. This is supposed to be the largest bas relief work on the rocks in the world, with the dimensions of 27mts by 9mts. As with the name there are various legends about the whole work. The most popular and accepted one is that Arjuna is doing Penance for getting a weapon from Gods to win the wars of Good over Evil. According to another legend Arjuna is doing it for decent of

Ganges on earth. Another legend accepts the main figure as Bhagirath Rishi doing penance for the decent of Ganges. But, whatever the difference of opinions there may be about these facts there is a unanimous view that the carvings are of very high artistic category and are in a very good shape even after a period of about 1500 years.



Just adjacent to the aforementioned site is another ancient site known as Krishna mandapa. This is a rock cut sophisticate cave with large panels. The walls of the cave have beautiful carvings of rural life woven with Krishna Leela. One section shows Krishna holding Goverdhana Mountain on his finger, under which the people, animals and other cattle are taking shelter from a storm. Another noteworthy bas relief is showing a rural man milking a cow, with the calf standing, whom the cow is licking with a curved tongue. Just above this relief is Krishna playing flute with humans and animals listening intently to the melody.

Another site in the same area is called Panch Pandava Mandapa or Pandav Chambers. The locals call the site as five bedrooms of Pandavas. This is an unfinished cave temple consisting of six pillars and five chambers. The outer pillars are finely carved and almost complete but the inner ones making the mandapa are incomplete as are the walls. We were told that this incompleteness of the cave temple has helped the architectural experts and researchers to understand better the process of carving and relief making of these ancient monuments.

The last site we saw was a huge boulder standing very precariously on another huge and slanting rock for many centuries or probably thousands of years. The locals call it by a funny name of Krishna Butter Ball, probably because the surrounding sites are related to Krishna Story.

From there we left for lunch in a local restaurant and enjoyed our last South Indian meal of this tour. In the afternoon we left for Chennai. In Chennai, it was raining and thus our programme of visiting a beach was shelved and we went to a huge shopping mall to while away our time and do some last minute shopping. Late in the evening we had a light dinner in some eatery and proceeded to airport for our late night flight

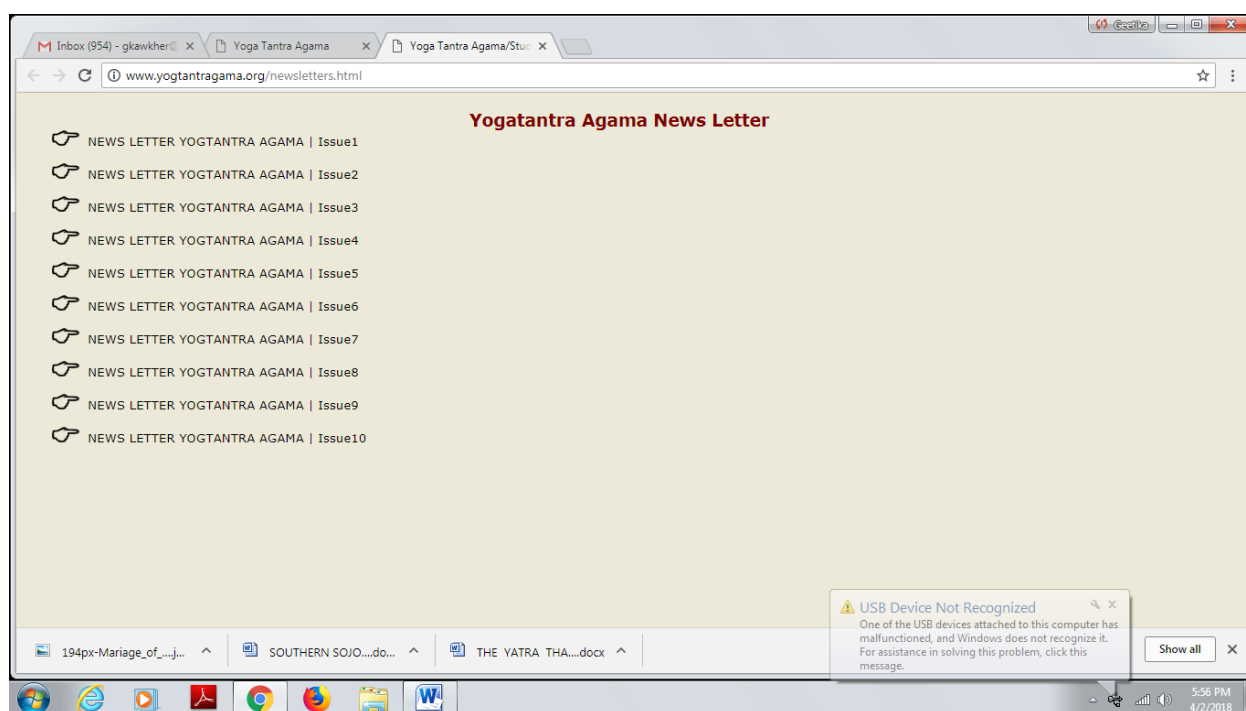
(Dr G.L Kaw is a medical practitioner based in Gandhinagar Gujarat with an avid interest in history, philosophy, classical Sanskrit and Persian literature)

A brief glimpse at the activities of YTA

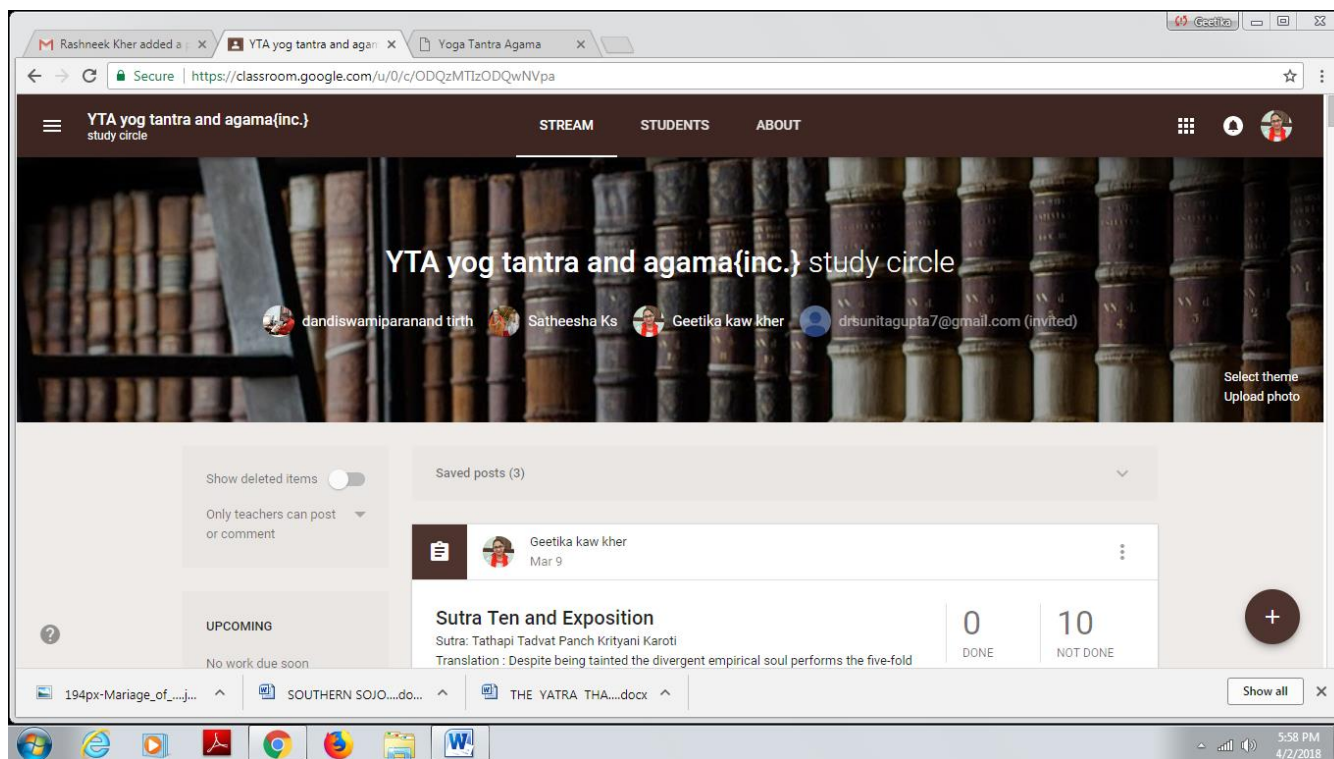
We at YTA believe in spreading the knowledge of arcane wisdom in a manner which would be relevant to contemporary times. With the blessings of our guru maharaj Swami Paranand Tirth ji we are planning to update our website and upload all our activities.



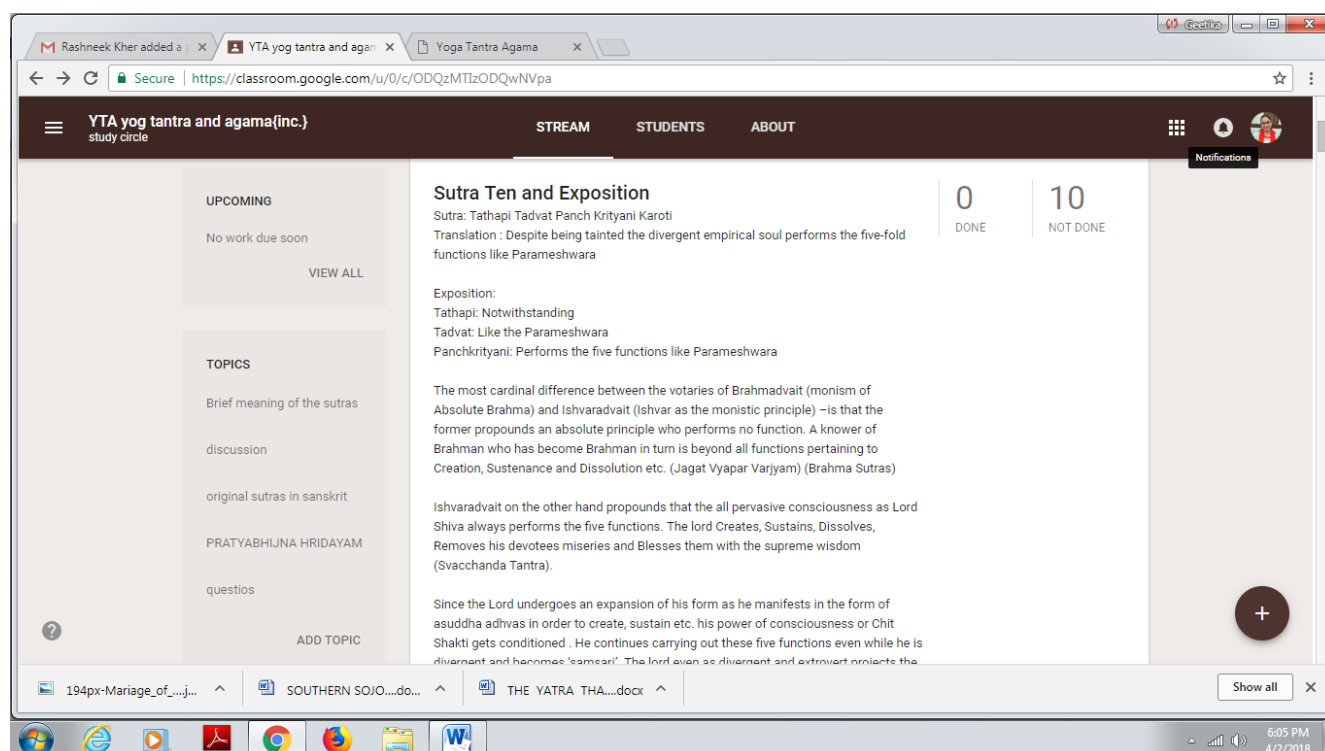
A link to all the ten previous 10 issues of the newsletter can be found in the website



To reach to more number of aspirants spread allover the globe in the divine guidance of Swamiji we have started a google classroom where we discuss seminal texts in detail. Currently we are discussing Kshemraj's Pratyabhijnahrdayam sutra by sutra. Each sutra is read its meaning disussed and Swamiji in his exposition explains the essence of these verses and their metaphysical import.



This classroom also provides us an online discussion forum to connect with other aspirants. Interested aspirants may send their email id to us at swamiparanand@gmail.com or gkawkher@gmail.com





YOGTANTRAGAMA
ISSN NO: 2454-888X



Published by : Rashneek Kher, 901-902, Iris Tower, Faridabad, Haryana, 121010 for YTA Inc.

E-mail: swamiparanand@gmail.com

Logo: Manik Chawla

